

A CITY OF GEARS.
A LEGACY OF SECRETS.
A KEY TO EVERYTHING.

THE BRASS GUARDIAN

THE AETHERHAVEN CHRONICLES

THE PAST TICKS. THE FUTURE WAITS.

AETHERHAVEN

A STEAMPUNK ADVENTURE SERIES
OF WONDER, DANGER & DISCOVERY

AETHER

City of Gears, D

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Aetherhaven was built around the Heart Engine, whose steam and aether continue to drive the city's secret tunnels and forgotten mechanisms lee beneath every bridge and boulevard.

Many wonders remain unmapped.

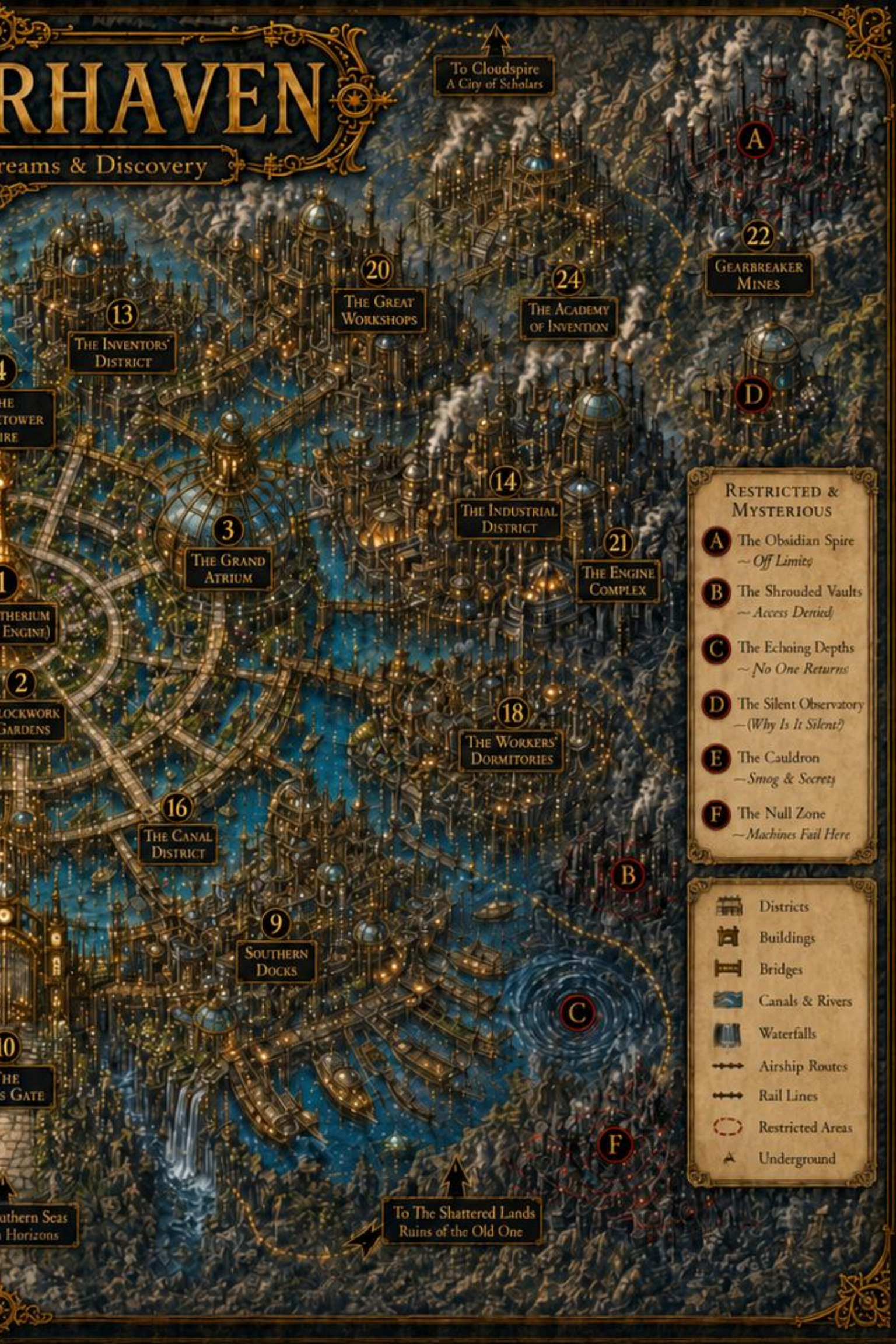
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The Brass Guardian and the Clockwork Princess

A Bedtime Adventure for Amelia

Far beyond the tallest mountains... Beyond the clouds where great steam airships sailed... Beyond maps that ended with the words "**Here There Be Wonders**"... stood the magnificent city of **Aetherhaven**.

Its streets were paved with polished brass. Its towers shimmered with copper roofs. Tiny mechanical birds sang every morning while enormous clock towers kept perfect time. And in a cozy workshop overlooking the city lived two famous adventurers.

Professor Elias Hawthorne... and his daughter... **Amelia Hawthorne**.

Most people thought Amelia's marvelous mechanical arm had been built because she needed it. But only a handful of people knew the truth. It had actually chosen her.

Hidden deep inside its tiny gears was a glowing crystal called an **Aether Heart**. It wasn't powered by steam. Or electricity. Or magic. It was powered by something much stronger.

Kindness.

Every time Amelia helped someone... Comforted someone... Shared a smile... Or showed courage... The crystal glowed just a little brighter.

Her father often said,

"The strongest machines aren't powered by engines, Amelia. They're powered by the people who use them."

One peaceful evening, as golden airships floated across the sunset, a tiny brass sparrow tapped on their workshop window.

Tap... Tap... Tap...

It carried a tiny scroll tied with blue ribbon. Amelia carefully opened it. It read:

To the Brass Guardian and the Clockwork Princess...

The Moon Garden has stopped blooming. Without its flowers, tonight's dreams cannot be delivered to sleeping children. Please help.

—The Keeper of Dreams

Amelia looked up with wide eyes.

"Dad..."

Professor Hawthorne smiled.

"I suppose bedtime can wait just a little longer for my little explorer."

Within minutes they were aboard their airship, **The Wayfinder**.

Steam hissed. Bronze propellers spun. Lanterns glowed warmly. The great ship drifted into the evening sky.

Below them stretched waterfalls, jungles, sparkling rivers, and villages lit by tiny golden lamps. Above them... Thousands of stars slowly woke for the night.

Soon they reached the Moon Garden. Usually it shimmered with silver flowers that opened only after sunset. Tonight... Every flower was closed. The entire garden was silent. Waiting.

Near the center stood an enormous machine shaped like a giant flower. It was ancient. Beautiful. And completely still. Professor Hawthorne adjusted his goggles.

"The Dream Engine."

He brushed away vines and dust.

"The gears are perfect. The pistons are perfect. The crystal is perfect. So why won't it awaken?"

Amelia gently placed her mechanical hand on the machine. Immediately... Her arm began to hum. Tiny gears spun. Soft blue lights glowed beneath the brass plates. The ancient flower slowly opened. But only halfway.

"It needs more than mechanics," Amelia whispered.

Just then she heard something. Very faint. Almost like crying. Hidden beneath the Dream Engine sat the tiniest little mechanical firefly she'd ever seen. One of its delicate wings had become bent beneath a gear. It had tried all night to free itself. No one had noticed. Except Amelia.

She carefully reached inside with her brass fingers. Tiny pistons moved with incredible precision.

Click... Click... Click...

The gear lifted. The little firefly fluttered free. It circled happily around Amelia's head. The moment it did... Her Aether Heart glowed brighter than ever before.

The Dream Engine suddenly roared to life. Huge petals unfolded. Thousands of silver flowers opened all at once. The entire garden sparkled like moonlight dancing on snow. Sweet scents drifted into the night. Tiny glowing seeds floated into the sky.

Professor Hawthorne smiled.

"I should have known."

Amelia tilted her head.

"Known what?"

"The machine wasn't broken. It was waiting. For someone kind enough to notice the smallest thing."

The Keeper of Dreams appeared in a swirl of shimmering stardust.

She thanked them with a gentle bow.

"Tonight," she said, "every child in the world will receive beautiful dreams because one little explorer chose kindness over hurry."

She handed Amelia a tiny silver flower.

"This blooms whenever someone remembers that helping others is the greatest adventure."

Amelia tucked it safely into her satchel.

The Wayfinder sailed home beneath a blanket of stars. They didn't speak much. Sometimes adventures are so wonderful that silence says everything.

As they approached Aetherhaven, the city lights twinkled below like scattered jewels. Professor Hawthorne looked toward Amelia.

"You know... I've explored every corner of the world... I've discovered lost cities... I've sailed through storms... I've climbed mountains no one believed existed."

He smiled.

"But my favorite adventure... is getting to be your dad."

Amelia leaned her head gently against his shoulder.

"My favorite adventure... is going with you."

Back at home, they tucked the Wayfinder safely into its hangar. The workshop grew quiet. The clocks ticked softly. The little brass sparrow perched happily by the window. And as Amelia drifted off to sleep, the tiny silver flower beside her bed glowed ever so gently.

Far away... In homes across the world... Children smiled in their sleep. They dreamed of airships. Friendly machines. Clockwork gardens. And brave explorers who knew that the strongest heroes weren't the ones with the biggest engines... They were the ones with the biggest hearts.

The End

And somewhere, high above the clouds, the Wayfinder waited patiently... ready for tomorrow's adventure.



The Brass Guardian and the Clockwork Explorer

A Day Aboard the Wayfinder

The first rays of morning sunlight spilled through the round brass windows of **The Wayfinder**, painting warm golden circles across Amelia's quilt. Before she even opened her eyes...

Clang!

A tiny wrench landed gently on her pillow. She smiled.

"Good morning to you too, Pip."

Perched on the bedpost sat Pip, the little brass sparrow. He chirped proudly, as if delivering important engineering news. Amelia stretched, her mechanical arm humming softly as the Aether Heart awakened with its familiar blue glow.

Outside, she could already hear footsteps on the deck. Her father was awake. That wasn't surprising. Professor Elias Hawthorne always woke before the sun.



Amelia hurried up the narrow staircase and onto the main deck. The morning air was cool and fresh. Far below floated clouds that looked soft enough to sleep on. Far above, bright blue sky stretched forever. Her father stood at the wheel with a steaming mug of tea.

"Morning, Captain." He laughed. "I'm only captain until my first mate arrives."

Amelia grinned.

"I'm here now."

"Excellent. Then we're officially underway."

They weren't rushing anywhere today. The Wayfinder wasn't on an adventure. She was simply sailing. Sometimes, Elias said, an explorer should travel without a destination. That's when the best discoveries happened.

Every morning aboard the Wayfinder followed its own cheerful routine. First... They checked the engines. The great brass Heart Engine glowed peacefully beneath the deck, filling the ship with its gentle rhythmic hum.

"Hmmm..."

Amelia listened carefully.

"It sounds happy today."

"It does," Elias agreed. *"Machines talk. They simply use different words."*

Together they polished gauges, tightened loose bolts, and checked the pressure in the steam lines. Amelia loved helping. Whenever she finished tightening a bolt, she'd proudly announce,

"Ship approved!"

Next came breakfast. The Wayfinder's galley wasn't very large. Just a tiny stove. A little oven. A hanging kettle. And shelves filled with jars collected from every corner of Aetherhaven.

Elias cooked blueberry flapjacks. Amelia stirred hot chocolate. Pip stole exactly one blueberry. As always.

"Evidence," Elias said, pointing at the purple stain on Pip's beak. Pip pretended not to notice.

After breakfast came Amelia's favorite job. The Repair Walk. The Wayfinder was always asking for little bits of attention. A squeaky hinge. A loose lantern. A railing that needed polishing. An old gear that appreciated a drop of oil.

Amelia carried a leather satchel full of tools almost as big as she was. Inside were tiny screwdrivers. Polishing cloths. Measuring rulers. And little brass tags that read:

REPAIRED BY A. HAWTHORNE

Every time she fixed something, she proudly tied on a new tag. By now... There were hundreds. Elias smiled every time he found another.

"I think one day people will believe I built this ship."

Amelia giggled.

"You started it. I just keep helping."

Late in the morning they climbed to the Observation Lounge. It was Amelia's favorite room aboard the Wayfinder. Tall windows wrapped almost all the way around. Maps covered one wall. Shelves overflowed with books. There were telescopes for watching distant islands. Spyglasses for spotting unusual birds.

And one enormous globe that slowly turned all by itself. Nobody knew how. Even Elias admitted, *"I didn't build that part."*

Which somehow made Amelia love it even more.



By lunchtime they had drifted beside a family of Cloud Whales. The enormous creatures floated lazily through the sky like living islands. One tiny whale calf swam close enough to peer into the Observation Lounge.

Amelia pressed her hand against the glass. The little whale gently bumped its nose against the window. Then it spun happily through the clouds.

Pip chirped excitedly. Elias simply smiled.

"Never chase them. They'll always visit if they choose."

That afternoon... There were no emergencies. No mysterious ruins. No ancient machines waking up. No impossible maps. Just quiet.

Amelia and Elias sat on the bow with sketchbooks. She drew floating castles. He sketched strange clouds. They guessed what each cloud looked like.

"That one looks like a dragon." Amelia exclaimed.

"No... A teapot."

"A dragon drinking tea."

"I can accept that." Elias conceded playfully.

As evening approached, lanterns around the ship slowly glowed to life. Nobody lit them. They simply knew. Warm golden light danced across polished brass. The engines settled into a slower rhythm.

Dinner was vegetable soup with warm bread.

Afterward, Elias read aloud from one of his favorite explorer journals while Amelia leaned comfortably against him.

Sometimes she asked questions. Sometimes she simply listened. The Wayfinder rocked gently beneath them. Almost like the ship enjoyed stories too.

When darkness finally covered the sky, the stars appeared one by one. Amelia climbed onto the upper deck.

There... She found her father quietly looking at the constellations.

"How does the Wayfinder always know where home is?" she asked.

Elias looked thoughtfully at the glowing compass beside the wheel.

"I don't think she follows the stars."

"No?"

"I think..." He rested a hand on the polished railing. *"...she follows the people she loves."*

Amelia smiled.

She wrapped both arms—one strong and mechanical, the other warm and ordinary—around her father in a hug. At that very moment... The Heart Engine gave one soft, happy hum.

"Hmmm..."



Pip chirped. The lanterns flickered gently. And the Wayfinder turned ever so slightly toward Aetherhaven, as though agreeing. Because adventures were wonderful. Discoveries were exciting. Ancient mysteries were waiting.

But every explorer knows a secret that isn't written on any map. The finest ship in the world isn't special because of its engines... It's special because of the family who calls it home.

And high above the clouds, beneath a sky full of stars, the Wayfinder carried her little family onward... Ready for whatever tomorrow might bring.





THE GRAND
ATRIUM

Canonical Gazetteer of Aetherhaven

City of Gears, Dreams & Discovery

Aetherhaven was not founded in the ordinary sense. The first settlers discovered the **Aetherium** already turning beneath the mountain, its mechanisms impossibly ancient and its power seemingly inexhaustible. The city grew outward from that central machine in concentric rings, with the Clockwork Gardens serving as both its living heart and the boundary between the civilization above and the forgotten mechanisms below.

Public Points of Interest

1. The Aetherium — The Heart Engine

At the precise center of Aetherhaven stands an enormous brass armillary surrounding a radiant sphere of condensed aether. Citizens call the structure the Heart Engine, although no modern engineer fully understands what it was originally designed to do.

Its power is distributed throughout the city by subterranean conduits known as the **Golden Veins**. The Aetherium occasionally changes its rhythm without warning, and every clock in the city loses exactly one second when it does.

Professor Elias Hawthorne believes the engine is not merely producing energy.

He believes it is waiting for something.

2. The Clockwork Gardens

The Clockwork Gardens form the beautiful inner ring surrounding the Aetherium. Living flowers grow alongside mechanical blossoms, brass vines climb stone trellises, and delicate clockwork insects pollinate plants from distant lands.

The Gardens appear perfectly planned, yet their pathways slowly change over time. A bridge present one morning may lead somewhere entirely different by sunset.

Amelia's mechanical arm responds strongly to several sealed mechanisms beneath the gardens, though no entrance has yet been found.

3. The Grand Atrium

A magnificent glass-domed conservatory containing tropical forests, rare flowers, indoor waterfalls and mechanical trees. Its central orrery tracks not only the sun and planets, but several celestial bodies unknown to Aetherhaven's astronomers.

The Atrium is a gathering place for explorers, scholars and visiting dignitaries. Every midnight, one glass panel briefly reflects a completely different sky.

The attendants insist it is merely an optical illusion.

None of them will stand beneath that panel after dark.

4. The Clocktower Spire

The Clocktower Spire rises above the northern edge of the Gardens and governs every public clock in Aetherhaven. Deep inside, thousands of gears turn in patterns maintained by the mysterious **Keepers of Time**.

Its great bell rings thirteen times once each year, although the date is never the same.

During the thirteenth toll, doors sometimes appear in the tower that cannot be found afterward.

5. The Waterfall Cascades

A series of immense waterfalls descends from the Skyward Cliffs into Aetherhaven's elevated reservoirs. Waterwheels built into the cliffs supplement the city's aether systems and drive many of its older mechanisms.

At night, the water occasionally glows with blue light. Objects lost elsewhere in the city have been discovered behind the falls days or even years later.

No one knows where the hidden currents originate.

6. The Reflection Canals

The innermost canals form a circular network around the Clockwork Gardens. Their unnaturally still water reflects the stars even beneath heavy clouds.

Travelers sometimes see people or places in the reflections that are not physically present. Most vanish when the water is disturbed.

Amelia once saw a reflection of herself standing beside a woman she had never met, holding an object shaped like an Aether Key.

7. The Starlight Walkways

These elevated pedestrian bridges are constructed from pale stone threaded with luminous brass. They absorb sunlight during the day and glow softly after dusk, creating shining paths across the Gardens.

Certain symbols become visible only under moonlight. Scholars have identified them as directional markings, but they do not point toward any known location.

Children say the paths lead to wherever someone most needs to go.

8. Airship Landing

The Gardens Airship Landing is a graceful elevated platform reserved for explorers, couriers, official visitors, and vessels in urgent need of assistance. Unlike the bustling commercial Aerial Docks, the Landing is quiet and closely integrated with the Clockwork Gardens, with brass walkways, flowering terraces, luminous guide lamps, and waterways passing beneath its platforms.

The *Wayfinder*, belonging to Elias and Amelia Hawthorne, is frequently moored at the **Wayfinder Berth**. Nearby, the reinforced **Emergency Repair Cradle** can receive experimental or badly damaged vessels that would be unsafe to approach the crowded commercial port.

Official dispatches pass through the glass-fronted **Courier House**, while the delicate instruments of the **Windglass Pavilion** measure wind, pressure, aether currents, and approaching storms. Travelers arriving here can follow the Starlight Walkways toward the Grand Atrium, Clocktower Spire, and central Gardens.

One berth remains permanently unused beneath a polished nameplate reading:

MORNINGSTAR

No vessel by that name appears in any current city registry. The gardeners polish the plate anyway.

9. The Southern Docks

The Southern Docks handle riverboats, fishing vessels, cargo barges and ships arriving from the Southern Seas. The district is filled with warehouses, taverns, rope makers and traders carrying goods from beyond the mapped world.

Sailors speak of a pale vessel that enters the harbor during heavy fog. It unloads sealed crates but never takes on supplies.

By sunrise, both ship and cargo have disappeared.

10. The Brass Gate

The ceremonial southern entrance to Aetherhaven is formed from colossal interlocking brass doors. Although they appear ornamental, the entire gate can seal within seconds if the city is threatened.

The gate's engraved figures depict the founding of Aetherhaven. One figure has Amelia's mechanical arm despite being carved centuries before her birth.

City officials claim the resemblance is coincidental.

11. The Government District

Home to the High Council, municipal ministries, courts, diplomatic chambers and the city archives. Its buildings are joined by pneumatic message tubes and guarded by clockwork sentinels.

The Council officially governs Aetherhaven, though its authority over the Heart Engine is largely ceremonial.

A sealed seat remains at the Council table for someone identified only as **The First Mechanist**.

12. The Merchant District

A crowded maze of markets, banks, auction houses and caravan exchanges. Nearly anything can be purchased here, provided one knows whom to ask and which alley to enter.

The Gilded Market sells exotic materials such as bottled lightning, memory glass and singing metal.

Its oldest shop, **The Last Lantern**, accepts no currency. The proprietor asks customers to trade a promise instead.

13. The Inventors' District

A lively neighborhood of laboratories, design halls, private workshops and testing grounds. Explosions are sufficiently common that bells announce whether citizens should evacuate or simply close their windows.

Inventors compete each year in the Grand Exhibition of Useful and Questionably Useful Devices.

Several machines in the district have independently drawn the same unfamiliar symbol: a circle divided by six keys.

14. The Industrial District

The largest manufacturing zone in Aetherhaven contains foundries, mills, assembly works and enormous steam-driven production lines. Most of the city's machinery, rail components and structural metal originate here.

Workers report hearing a second set of machines operating beneath the factory floors during the night shift.

The official plans show nothing below them except solid rock.

15. The Old City

The oldest inhabited portion of Aetherhaven consists of narrow streets, leaning buildings and forgotten courtyards constructed before the modern district system. Many structures contain sealed rooms or foundations far older than the buildings above them.

The Old City is known for antique shops, hidden libraries and families whose histories reach back to the first settlers.

Its street signs occasionally display names that no longer exist on any map.

16. The Canal District

A busy network of locks, bridges, water markets and canal-side residences connecting the city's central and southern districts. Barges transport people and goods more efficiently than the crowded streets.

The district's lock keepers maintain a chain of unmarked gates that they refuse to open.

They call the waterway beyond them the **Thirteenth Canal**, although only twelve appear on official maps.

17. The Entertainment District

The Entertainment District is Aetherhaven's brightest and most spirited quarter, filled with grand theaters, lively music halls, elegant restaurants, bustling gaming rooms, mechanical carnivals, and mysterious illusion houses. After sunset, colored aether lamps illuminate its rooftops and elevated promenades, making the district shimmer across the city.

Its most celebrated venue is the **Theatre of Impossible Things**, where performances occasionally feature people, conversations, or events that have not yet occurred. The actors insist this is merely the work of unusually imaginative playwrights.

Standing close to the Cauldron approaches, the district welcomes merchants, performers, travelers, and visitors from every corner of Aetherhaven. Its streets carry a noticeable Brass Watch presence, especially after midnight, when private clubs open, unofficial markets appear, and the evening's entertainment sometimes becomes considerably more adventurous than advertised.

Most visitors come for the spectacle.

A few leave wondering whether they watched the performance—or whether the performance was watching them.

18. The Workers' Dormitories

A vast residential district housing miners, engineers, foundry workers and their families. Though modest in appearance, it possesses a strong community of kitchens, schools, meeting halls and rooftop gardens.

An old network of service tunnels beneath the district is used by workers during emergencies.

Some passages extend far beyond the factories they were supposedly built to serve.

19. The Aerial Docks

The Aerial Docks are Aetherhaven's great gateway to the skies, where elevated mooring towers, cargo cranes, customs platforms, and immense dirigible hangars rise above a constant bustle of crews, merchants, couriers, and travelers.

From the **Mooring Crown**, vessels depart for the Skyward Isles, Cloudspire, and settlements throughout the known world. Visitors can watch cargo move through the **Customs Concourse**, explore the busy **Cargo Exchange**, or admire the route maps and ship models displayed in the **Navigator's Gallery**.

The port is governed by Captain Mara Voss from the **Harbormaster's Tower**, where every arrival and departure is recorded—at least in theory.

At the far end of Hangar Row stands a locked structure marked **Dock Zero**. It predates the rest of the port and appears on no reliable construction record.

On stormy nights, its mooring lights sometimes awaken by themselves, shining into empty clouds as though guiding a vessel that has not yet become visible.

20. The Great Workshops

The Great Workshops are sprawling halls where the city's finest mechanists construct locomotives, airships, automata and experimental engines. Whole buildings can be rearranged internally using tracks embedded in the floors.

Elias Hawthorne maintains a private workspace in the eastern hall.

One unfinished machine stored there has been slowly assembling itself from discarded parts.

21. The Engine Complex

A fortified industrial facility that regulates the transfer of power from the Aetherium into Aetherhaven's public systems. Its pressure chambers, turbines and distribution regulators must operate continuously.

Engineers refer to its deepest control room as the **Pulse Chamber**. Access is restricted to senior operators.

Every operator who has worked there reports hearing something enormous breathing behind the walls.

22. The Gearbreaker Mines

Carved into the northeastern mountains, these mines provide aetherstone, iron, copper and rare crystalline ores. Miners travel downward aboard enormous geared lifts capable of reaching depths far beneath the city.

Recent excavations uncovered a perfectly smooth metal wall engraved with six empty sockets.

Mining around the structure has been suspended, though the wall can still be heard ticking.

23. The Observatory

Built on the southwestern cliffs, the Observatory studies the planets, stars, air currents and distant aether storms. Its enormous rotating lenses can detect objects far beyond the visible sky.

The astronomers recently identified a dark celestial body approaching Aetherhaven's system.

It appears only through the Observatory's oldest lens, and it grows closer whenever the Heart Engine changes rhythm.

24. The Academy of Invention

Aetherhaven's foremost school of engineering, natural philosophy, exploration and applied imagination. Its students learn everything from aeronautics and clockwork design to cartography and the responsible handling of unstable aether.

The Academy houses the **Hall of Unfinished Ideas**, where inventions abandoned by previous generations are preserved.

One sealed display contains a mechanical arm almost identical to Amelia's, labeled:

Prototype II — Awaiting the Bearer.

No record of Prototype I has been found.

Restricted and Mysterious Locations

A. The Obsidian Spire — Off Limits

A black tower rises from the northeastern heights, seemingly carved from a single piece of glass-like stone. No doors or windows can be seen from outside, and neither snow nor rain appears to touch it.

The tower predates Aetherhaven and is surrounded by a permanent military cordon.

At sunset, silhouettes occasionally move behind walls that should be solid.

B. The Shrouded Vaults — Access Denied

Hidden within the eastern cliffs, the Vaults are protected by heavy doors, pressure seals and Council guards. Officially, they contain dangerous inventions confiscated for public safety.

Unofficially, the oldest vaults existed before the Council itself.

Amelia's arm once pointed directly toward them and displayed a message in an unknown script:

THE OTHERS ARE STILL SLEEPING.

C. The Echoing Depths — No One Returns

A vast whirlpool turns continuously beyond the southeastern edge of the city. Beneath it lies a vertical chasm whose depth has never been measured.

Expeditions lowered into the Depths have transmitted voices belonging to people who were not aboard their vessels.

The final transmission is always the same:

"We found the city beneath the city."

D. The Silent Observatory — Why Is It Silent?

An abandoned domed structure stands alone in the northeastern mountains. It was once Aetherhaven's original observatory, but all records concerning its closure have been removed.

No sound can be heard inside—not footsteps, voices or even machinery.

Its telescope is not aimed at the sky.

It points directly toward the Heart Engine.

E. The Cauldron — Smog and Secrets

RESTRICTED DISTRICT — ENTRY STRONGLY DISCOURAGED

The Cauldron lies in a deep industrial basin beyond the **Ash Line**, where furnace towers, crowded workshops, salvage markets, slag canals, and abandoned rail cuts vanish beneath layers of steam, soot, and chemical haze. From the upper city, the entire district appears to simmer like a vast blackened vessel.

Ordinary citizens are warned not to cross the fortified **Cinder Gates** without official cause or a trusted guide. Although the Brass Watch holds legal authority there, the Cauldron answers to the **Cinder Regent**, the **Furnace Court**, and its own severe body of customs known as Ash Law. Watch officers enter carefully; attempts to impose control are rarely forgotten and never welcomed.

Aetherhaven officially condemns the district as a refuge for fugitives, felons, smugglers, forbidden inventors, and those who have disappeared from respectable society. Yet rare components, impossible repairs, unusual medicines, and expertise unavailable anywhere else continue to reach the greater city from its markets.

Visitors are advised to remain outside.

Those who ignore the warning may discover hidden **Ninth Rooms**, machines with histories no archive records, and people who know exactly which secrets Aetherhaven has paid the Cauldron to keep.

F. The Null Zone — Machines Fail Here

In the southeastern wilderness lies a circular region where engines stall, compasses spin and clockwork mechanisms cease moving. Even the Aetherium's energy cannot cross its boundary.

Mechanical devices restart immediately upon leaving, usually with their clocks set to the same unknown date.

Amelia's arm does not shut down inside the Null Zone.

Instead, it becomes stronger.

And somewhere beneath the silent ground, something begins answering it.

The Brass Guardian & The Clockwork Explorer

No one remembers when the city of **Aetherhaven** was built. Some say it rose from the jungle after an ancient civilization discovered how to trap steam inside crystals. Others claim it was built atop the ruins of a forgotten empire whose machines never truly stopped running.

Above its copper domes drift leviathan airships. Beneath its streets, thousands of miles of brass pipes pulse with pressurized steam that powers everything from elevators to mechanical birds.

Among all its inventors and explorers, none are more recognizable than **Professor Elias Hawthorne** and his daughter, **Amelia Hawthorne**.



The Hawthornes

Professor Elias Hawthorne

The Brass Guardian

Explorer, archaeologist, mechanist and father of Amelia Hawthorne.

Elias earned the title **Brass Guardian** after preventing an unstable ancient engine from destroying an expeditionary settlement. He is respected throughout Aetherhaven but has an uncomfortable relationship with the High Council, whose members believe he has uncovered far more about the Heart Engine than he has reported.

He is intelligent, compassionate and tremendously resourceful, but he carries a deep fear that his search for ancient technology placed Amelia in danger. This sometimes makes him overprotective—especially when Amelia's mechanical arm responds to something he cannot explain.

Elias keeps a locked journal aboard the *Wayfinder*. On its cover is a symbol of six intersecting keys. Amelia has never seen him open it.

"Every machine tells a story. The greatest ones write history."

Professor Hawthorne is an explorer, inventor, and archaeologist obsessed with finding the mythical **Heart Engine**—a machine rumored to be capable of powering an entire civilization forever.

Years ago, during an expedition into the Clockwork Jungle, his research team uncovered an ancient vault. Inside was a dormant machine unlike anything humanity had ever built.

The machine awakened. The explosion destroyed much of the expedition and nearly claimed his daughter's arm. For years Elias blamed himself.

He devoted every waking hour to learning the forgotten engineering of the Ancients—not merely to repair what had been lost, but to build something greater.

Amelia Hawthorne

The Clockwork Explorer

Young explorer, apprentice inventor and bearer of the Aether Gauntlet.

Amelia is curious, observant and far more courageous than her father would sometimes prefer. Her mechanical arm can interact with ancient mechanisms that do not respond to anyone else. It is still developing new abilities, occasionally without warning.

Where Elias sees danger, Amelia often sees someone—or something—that needs help.

The ancient machines call her by a title she does not yet understand:

The Bearer of the Living Key.

"I'm not broken... I'm upgraded."

Amelia never viewed her injury as a tragedy. To her, it became the greatest adventure imaginable. Her mechanical arm is not a prosthetic. It is **The Aether Gauntlet**—the only surviving interface capable of communicating with Ancient Machines.

What began as a protective brace slowly evolved as her father discovered lost technologies.

Every expedition adds another improvement:

- Clockwork servos
- Steam-assisted pistons
- Precision gyroscopes
- Pressure regulators
- Articulated brass fingers
- Micro-gear muscles
- Crystal-powered sensors
- A miniature steam boiler hidden beneath engraved armor plates

The arm can lift several times her own weight, repair delicate mechanisms, and even awaken machines that have slept for centuries. Yet the greatest mystery... No one actually understands why it works. The Ancient Machines respond only to Amelia.

Their Greatest Discovery

Legend speaks of six **Aether Keys** scattered across the world. Each unlocks one section of the Heart Engine. Every explorer seeks them. Every empire wants them. But only Amelia's arm can safely retrieve them from the ancient mechanisms guarding each vault.

Together they travel aboard the airship **The Wayfinder**, crossing floating islands, forgotten temples, subterranean railways, and cities suspended by enormous gears.

Every adventure brings them closer to the Heart Engine...

...and closer to discovering who truly built it.

Their Reputation

Throughout Aetherhaven they are known simply as:

The Brass Guardian and The Clockwork Explorer.

People don't whisper because they're famous. They whisper because whenever strange machines awaken, impossible maps appear, or forgotten doors begin turning again...

The Hawthornes are already on their way.

For adventure isn't something they seek—it's something that seems to seek them first.



CATALOG No. AH-1-001

The Hawthorne Explorer's Crest

Family crest and expedition seal
of Professor Elias Hawthorne
and the Hawthorne line.
Commonly found on documents,
instrument cases, field journals,
and the Wayfinder.

DATE DISCOVERED:

17th of Brassfire, 1887

LOCATION:

Shrouded Vaults, Sector F-12

RECOVERED BY:

E. Hawthorne

WAX SEAL IMPRESSION



FOUND IN: FIELD JOURNAL No. 7



ARCHIVIST NOTES

Crest appears on items predating the formal founding
of the Society of Explorers.
Key motif matches six ancient key sockets
discovered in Sector F-12.
Further study required.

CONDITION: Good

CLASSIFICATION: Family / Expedition

ACCESS: Restricted

VERIFIED
Brooker

11/23/88

EXPEDITION PATCH (WORN)



FOUND ON: WAYFINDER INSTRUMENT CASE



*Carried on every voyage.
May it guide us home.*

BRASS STAMP IMPRINT



*Impression taken
from hidden compartment
beneath observer seat,
Wayfinder.*

Family crest
adopted by
Jonathan Hawthorne
following the
Expedition to
Eastreach.
Year 1127 A.H.



*The lantern
represents
discovery.
The wings,
freedom.
The key,
truth.*

PROF. E. HAWTHORNE'S SKETCH



*More
than a
family--
a purpose.
E. H.*

Add subtle gear within compass.

PROPERTY OF THE
SOCIETY OF EXPLORERS
AETHERHAVEN

The People and Powers of Aetherhaven

A Canonical Dramatis Personae for the Brass Guardian Stories

Aetherhaven is not divided simply between heroes and villains. It is a city of competing loyalties, inherited promises, concealed histories and people who may help the Hawthornes in one adventure while opposing them in the next.

Some protect the city. Some wish to control it. Some believe Aetherhaven was never humanity's city to begin with.

Public Figures of Aetherhaven

Chancellor Octavia Vale

First Voice of the High Council

Chancellor Octavia Vale, is the calm and dignified public leader of Aetherhaven.

She is admired for settling disputes without violence and for maintaining peace among the city's guilds, merchants, labor interests, explorers, and industrial powers. Octavia rarely raises her voice. Her authority comes from patience, careful listening, and an ability to persuade bitter rivals to accept compromise without making them feel defeated.

She genuinely cares about Aetherhaven and the people who live within it.

Octavia believes leadership sometimes requires difficult decisions, temporary secrecy, and restraint when public fear could cause greater harm. Her personal principle is:

Stability is a duty, not an excuse.

She presides over the High Council without occupying one of its twelve active seats. After the councillors have debated and voted, it is Octavia's responsibility to speak their decision as one civic authority.

Though cautious, she is not weak. She will authorize evacuations, trade restrictions, district closures, or intervention by the Brass Watch when lives are at risk. Her first instinct is always de-escalation, but her final responsibility is the safety of Aetherhaven.

Octavia is respected because she listens before she speaks, remembers those who petition the Council, and understands that preserving peace requires more than simply ending an argument.

She also knows that peace maintained without honesty cannot remain stable forever.

Chief Inspector Beatrice Thorne

Commander of the Brass Watch

Chief Inspector Beatrice Thorne commands the Brass Watch, Aetherhaven's constables, investigators, canal patrol, emergency responders, and clockwork sentinel forces. Stern, methodical, and nearly impossible to deceive, she is responsible for determining when a strange occurrence is a civic inconvenience, a criminal act, or the beginning of something far more dangerous.

At first, Thorne views Professor Elias Hawthorne and Amelia Hawthorne as troublesome adventurers who leave behind damaged rooftops, disrupted canals, violated procedures, and incident reports no reasonable investigator should ever have to file. Over time, however, she comes to recognize that the Hawthornes are not causing Aetherhaven's deepest problems. They are often the first to discover them.

Her respect is earned slowly. Once given, it is durable.

Thorne's left eye is an intricate mechanical lens capable of detecting heat, aether residue, hidden writing, pressure disturbance, mechanical stress, and forensic traces invisible to ordinary sight. She claims it was damaged in the line of duty, which is true but incomplete. In reality, she lost the eye during a classified expedition into the Shrouded Vaults—an operation the High Council later erased from the record and publicly denied ever occurred.

The mission changed more than her vision. It convinced Thorne that official truth in Aetherhaven is not always the same as actual truth.

Since then, she has become a relentless guardian of evidence, redundancy, and accurate records. She trusts procedure, but not blindly; authority, but not absolutely; and secrecy only when it protects lives rather than reputations.

Thorne serves the city before she serves the Council.

Behind her formal bearing, she keeps private files on cases that shift after filing, witnesses who disappear from official records, and evidence the city seems intent on forgetting. Her mechanical lens has begun revealing traces of erased writing, altered reports, and structures that should no longer exist.

She has not told the High Council that her eye sometimes sees things their records do not.

She has not told the Brass Watch that one sealed fragment from the Shrouded Vaults reacts to Amelia's gauntlet.

And she has not yet decided whether the truth buried beneath Aetherhaven is something the law can contain—or something the law was designed to keep hidden.

Doctor Elara Quill

Chancellor of the Academy of Invention

Elara Quill is one of the city's most brilliant scholars. She speaks rapidly, carries several notebooks at once and frequently forgets whether she has eaten.

She becomes Amelia's informal mentor, teaching her engineering, natural philosophy and the important difference between a controlled experiment and "pressing a glowing button to see what happens."

Elara discovered the mechanical arm marked **Prototype II** within the Academy's Hall of Unfinished Ideas.

She has quietly removed its original records from the archives.

Not because she wishes to hide them from Amelia—but because someone else has begun searching for them.

Master Gideon Brasswell

Keeper of the Engine Complex

Gideon Brasswell is the chief engineer responsible for delivering power from the Heart Engine throughout Aetherhaven.

Broad-shouldered, soot-covered and endlessly practical, he trusts pressure gauges more than politicians. He initially dismisses stories of ancient intelligence as superstition.

Yet Gideon has heard the breathing behind the walls of the Pulse Chamber.

He also knows the truth about the city's power supply:

The Heart Engine has not been producing more energy as Aetherhaven grows.

Something beneath the city has simply been awakening.

Captain Mara Voss

Harbormaster of the Aerial Docks

Captain Mara Voss once commanded the celebrated exploration vessel *Resolute*. She now governs Aetherhaven's Aerial Docks and oversees the smaller emergency landing platform near the Clockwork Gardens. She knows every reputable captain, unreliable smuggler, customs officer, dock mechanic, and airship worth knowing—and several vessels that officially do not exist.

Blunt, fearless, and fiercely loyal, Mara treats Amelia Hawthorne as a genuine explorer rather than a child accompanying adults. She trusts Amelia with real responsibility, though she occasionally conspires with Elias to keep particularly dangerous information from her. Amelia has learned that Mara's silences usually conceal concern rather than distrust.

Mara and Elias share a long history of expeditions aboard the *Resolute*. Their friendship survived storms, mechanical failures, Council inquiries, and the expedition that changed Amelia's life. Mara is one of the few people who can challenge Elias when his fear for his daughter begins outweighing his faith in her.

The *Resolute* disappeared during its final voyage and returned seven months later with every clock aboard running backward. Mara insists only nineteen days passed for the crew. The official record identifies her as the vessel's only remaining passenger, though she was its captain. Its crew manifests now contradict one another, and several names Mara remembers no longer appear in any public record.

Mara refuses to describe what happened during the voyage. She does, however, maintain a private black ledger of ships, passengers, and arrivals that the official records forget.

She confiscated the Passenger of Dock Zero's future-coded ticket after repeated attempts to enter the reserved Morningstar berth. The damaged name field cannot confirm that the ticket belongs to him, but symbols within its transit code match markings Mara saw during the *Resolute*'s final voyage.

She has not told the Passenger that the Morningstar may not arrive for forty-seven years.

She has also not told the High Council that the *Resolute*'s backward chronometer has begun counting toward the same date.

And each night, before leaving her office, Mara looks through the docks toward the empty reserved berth.

Not to see whether the Passenger is still waiting.

To make certain the Morningstar has not arrived early.

Juniper Bell

Keeper of the Clockwork Gardens

Juniper Bell, is the gentle and eccentric caretaker most visitors associate with the Gardens.

She dresses in layered green coats filled with seeds, pruning tools, folded notes, tiny bells, and small mechanical insects that appear to possess personalities of their own. Juniper seems to know when the Gardens' pathways will shift, which flowers may safely be touched, and which quiet clearings should be left entirely alone.

She speaks to the Gardens as though they are one living creature and listens as though they answer.

Juniper is one of the Conservancy of Living Mechanisms' most visible members, although she is not its First Tender and holds no ordinary administrative rank. Her older title places her between the Gardens and the people who enter them. She does not command their living paths, but she can ask them to reveal, conceal, or close routes—including those leading to hidden gardens rarely seen by the public.

Juniper is warm, patient, and deeply protective. Her eccentricity should never be mistaken for foolishness. She notices fear expressed as malfunction, distress hidden inside repetition, and the moment a visitor stops behaving like a guest.

When asked how long she has cared for the Gardens, Juniper gives a different answer each time.

The oldest known painting of the Clockwork Gardens was created more than two centuries ago. A woman standing beside the Aetherium appears to be Juniper. She looks exactly the same.

Tamsin Pike

Warden of the Thirteenth Canal

Tamsin is a young canal keeper with an old brass key hanging from her neck. She knows every lock, tunnel and waterway beneath Aetherhaven.

She is clever, mischievous and usually willing to bend regulations for a worthwhile adventure. Amelia quickly befriends her.

Tamsin inherited her key from her grandfather, who warned her never to use it on the unmarked lock beneath Pike Bridge.

The key has recently begun turning by itself whenever Amelia passes nearby.



AETHERHAVEN ARCHIVES ARTIFACT FILE

CATALOG No. AH-1-017

TAMSIN PIKE'S BRASS KEY

Family Heirloom - Pike Line

*Held for three generations. Origin unknown.
Purpose unconfirmed.*

RECORD TYPE:

Physical Artifact

CLASSIFICATION:

Personal Relic

CURRENT STATUS:

*In Family Custody
(T. Pike)*



Scale
Actual Size

FAMILY WAX IMPRESSION



*Imprint
taken from
the bow.*

*Tamsin Pike
age 17*

METAL RUBBING (BOW)



*Rubbing
reveals deeper
lines beneath
surface wear.*

NOTES FROM TAMSIN PIKE

*Grandmother said this key opened
a door that should never be opened
twice. She never said where the door
was. I've tried the obvious places.
Nothing.*

*The symbol... I don't recognize it.
It isn't in any Academy book.
Feels... different when I hold it.
Lighter, somehow. Like it wants
to turn.*

DETAIL: BOW INLAY (MAGNIFIED)



*Tiny nicks
around the
symbol suggest
centuries of
handling.
Edges softened
but never
polished clean.*

PIKE FAMILY LINEAGE

Euphemia Pike (Grandmother)
→ Beatrice Pike (Mother)
→ Tamsin Pike (Current Custodian)

*Passed down with no explanation.
Only this warning:
"Guard it. Or it will choose for you."*



CATALOG HISTORY

- 452 AE Offered to Academy of Invention by Beatrice Pike
- 452 AE Examined by Archivist L. Maren
- 452 AE Symbol unknown - No match in Index of Known Glyphs
- 452 AE Returned to family custody at request
- 452 AE Future study pending discovery of related mechanism



UNKNOWN SYMBOL - NO MATCH FOUND



*Closest comparisons: None conclusive.
May represent an early Mechanist sigil,
or a language predating current records.*

?

Orin Flint

Foreman of the Gearbreaker Mines

Orin Flint is a respected mining foreman known for placing his workers' safety above profit or politics. He has spent most of his life beneath the northeastern mountains and can identify an underground chamber by the echo of a single hammer strike.

Orin ordered excavation halted after discovering the metal wall with six sockets.

The Council publicly praised his caution.

Privately, someone has repeatedly ordered him to resume digging.

Orin has refused—and now hears machinery moving on the other side of the wall.

Lucian Wren

Aetherhaven's Celebrated Inventor

Lucian is handsome, theatrical and extremely talented. His inventions attract crowds, investors and occasional fire brigades.

He views Elias as an outdated adventurer and Amelia as both a fascinating mystery and an inconvenient rival. He frequently competes with the Hawthornes, but he is not cruel. When genuine danger appears, Lucian usually does the right thing—after first complaining that the danger has ruined his coat.

Unknown to the public, most of Lucian's recent breakthroughs originated from a box of anonymous blueprints delivered to his workshop.

Each design contains one component whose purpose he cannot understand.

Together, those components may form something much larger.

Barnaby Wren

Proprietor of the Last Lantern

Barnaby runs the oldest shop in the Merchant District. His shelves contain impossible objects: unopened letters from the future, keys without locks, maps of places that may not exist and bottles filled with forgotten songs.

He never accepts money.

His price is always a promise.

Barnaby is warm toward Amelia and distrustful of Elias. He once told the professor:

“You have already broken the promise you came here to make.”

Elias has no memory of meeting him before.

Madame Celestine Mirrow

Mistress of the Theatre of Impossible Things

Celestine is the elegant and enigmatic owner of Aetherhaven's most celebrated theatre. Her productions sometimes portray events before they happen.

She claims her writers simply possess remarkable imaginations.

Celestine wears a mirrored mask during every performance. Beneath it, some say she has no face. Others claim she bears the same markings that occasionally glow across Amelia's arm.

She never predicts the future directly.

She stages warnings and allows the audience to misunderstand them.

Public Organizations

The High Council of Aetherhaven

The High Council of Aetherhaven is the city's central governing body, responsible for law, trade, infrastructure, taxation, public safety, and relations among Aetherhaven's districts, guilds, and chartered institutions.

The Council has twelve active seats:

- one delegate from each of the Eight Founding Engineering Guilds,
- and four civic representatives speaking for Aetherhaven's historic district quarters.

The Chancellor presides over the Council, administers its decisions, and serves as the public voice of the city.

Council members frequently disagree over commerce, labor, exploration, policing, district rights, mechanical personhood, public spending, and the proper limits of ancient technology.

They are united by one principle:

The Heart Engine must continue operating.

This belief is formalized as the **Doctrine of Continuance** and treated as the foundation upon which every other law depends.

Behind the Chancellor's dais stands a sealed thirteenth chair. It is reserved for the **First Mechanist**, an office older than the modern Council and supposedly empowered to overrule the Chancellor, command the founding guilds, and assume authority during a threat to Aetherhaven's continued existence. No living citizen has seen the chair occupied.

Every formal session begins with the declaration:

The Twelve are called. The Thirteenth remains sealed.

The Society of Explorers

A respected organization of cartographers, archaeologists, natural philosophers and airship captains. Elias Hawthorne is one of its most celebrated—and frequently censured—members.

The Society maintains maps of the known world, expedition records and a museum of recovered artifacts.

Its maps contain small blank regions marked:

Intentionally Uncharted.

Only the Society's Inner Compass knows why.

CATALOG No. SE-1-002

Seal of the
Society of Explorers

Official seal of the Society of Explorers of Aetherhaven. Impression found on authenticated expedition documents, charter licenses, and field dispatches. First issued in the Year 769 A.H. Current iteration adopted in the Year 1043 A.H.

DATE RECOVERED:
12th of Gearsday, 1126 A.H.

LOCATION:
Shrouded Vaults, Archive N-7

RECOVERED BY:
E. Hawthorne

ITEM CONDITION:
Good - minor edge wear and ink erosion.



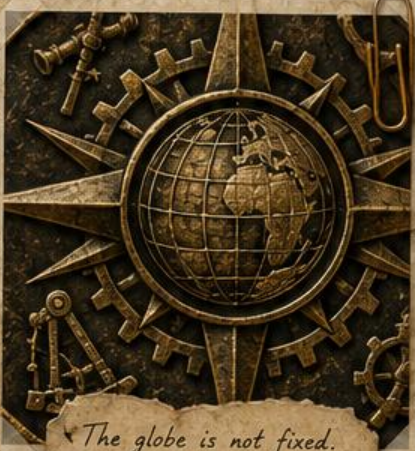
The Society stands for curiosity, discovery, and the pursuit of truth beyond the known.

- Society Charter Preamble



SEAL VERIFIED

DETAIL: CENTRAL COMPASS & GLOBE



The globe is not fixed. It turns.

Observation: continents move slightly from plate to plate. Intentional?

EARLY DESIGN SKETCH (YEAR 767 A.H.)



More prominent compass.

Add lantern - guidance through darkness.

Globe at heart of all exploration. Knowledge of the world is our true north.

WAX SEAL IMPRESSION



SEAL IN USE - EXPEDITION CHARTER



EMBOSSED DOCUMENT IMPRESSION



Embossing used on formal correspondence and licenses.

NOTES ON VARIANTS

769 A.H. First Issue (unconfirmed)	812 A.H. Simplified Compass	1043 A.H. Current Iteration	1119 A.H. Field Use Version

ARCHIVIST NOTES

Several authenticated records bear subtle differences in the inner ring and globe orientation. Whether due to hand crafting or deeper meaning unknown. Further comparison with High Council archives recommended.

CLASSIFICATION: Official / Foundational

ACCESS LEVEL: Restricted

REFERENCE: Society Charter, Article I



Seal of the
Society of Explorers

Official seal of the Society of Explorers, as used on charters, expedition credentials, and authenticated correspondence.

The inner compass signifies guidance. The wings, pursuit of knowledge. The lantern, truth in dark places.

DATE ISSUED:
Year 312 A.H.

FIRST RECORDED USE:
*Founding Charter
Year 0 A.H.*

MATERIAL:
Pressed Brass

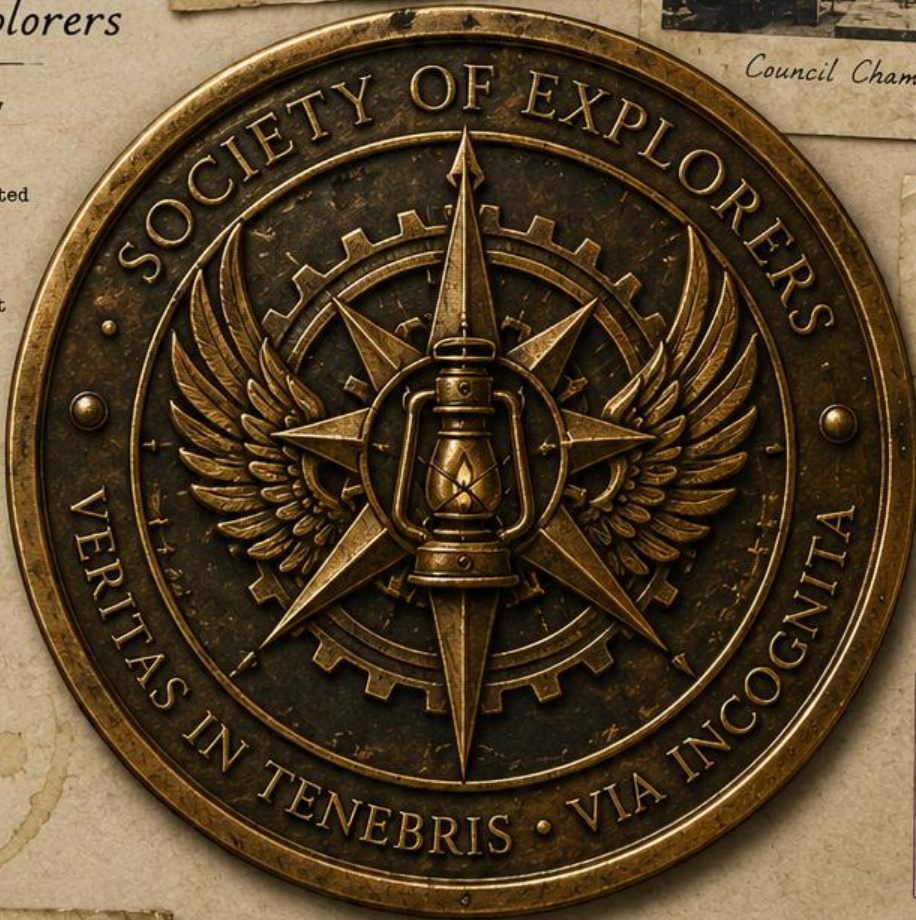
DIAMETER:
4.7 cm

*The Council grants this seal
only to those who venture
where maps end.
- Founding Charter, Article I*



*Council Chamber, High Seat
Year 295 A.H.*

*Observe the
thirteen points.
Not a flaw.
- E.H.*



VERIFIED
AUTHENTIC
D. Quill
CHIEF ARCHIVIST
SOCIETY OF EXPLORERS

WAX IMPRESSION



ARCHIVIST SKETCH



*Note the concealed glyph
within the inner ring.* →

INNER RING DETAIL (ENHANCED)



*Unrecorded symbol.
Predates the Society.
Origin unknown.*

SOCIETY OF EXPLORERS
EXPEDITION CREDENTIAL



*This certifies that
Prof. Elias Hawthorne
is a recognized Explorer of the Society
and is granted all rights and access
pursuant to the Charter.*

ISSUED: *17 of Brassfire, 312 A.H.*

SIGNED: *D. Quill*
CHIEF ARCHIVIST



*Seal affixed to official
dispatch satchel.*

ARCHIVIST NOTES

*Seal appears on all
authenticated Society
documents and field
cases.*

*Inner glyph may relate
to the Six Keys.
Further investigation
authorized.*

FILED
11/23/88



The Changing Paths of the Gardens

THREE SURVEYS OF AETHERHAVEN'S CLOCKWORK GARDENS

The layout of the paths is not static but follows unknown laws. When aligned to true north, the arrangement of the third survey forms the Six-Key Sigil.

SURVEY I Pre-Rising

12th of Emberfall,
447 AE

Before the waters came
The Gardens rested
upon ancient ground.
Streams and irrigation
channels fed the
Aethorium at
the center.



KEY NOTES

- ✦ Paths meander freely
- ✦ No discernible pattern beyond natural growth
- ✦ Ground level throughout
- ✦ Streams & irrigation channels present



SOUTH GATE
(Exterior Elevation)

NOTES FROM THE SOCIETY OF EXPLORERS

The Gardens did not remain unchanged after the Rising. Engineers recorded accelerated growth of waterways and the expansion of districts in the decades that followed. These are the earliest known maps after the waters came.

SURVEY II Early Post-Rising

3rd of Thalendorn,
454 AE

Waters rose across the
lowlands. The Gardens
elevated on new
foundations. New
bridges and
causeways built.



KEY NOTES

- + First waters fill the basin
- + Tenoned foundations and elevation supports
- + New bridges & causeways added
- + Districts in early stages of construction



EAST PAVILION
(Under Construction)

LEGEND

- Aethorium (Heart Engine)
- Primacy Gates
- Bridges & Causeways
- Districts / Buildings
- Paths
- Waterways
- Elevated Foundations

SURVEY III Post-Rising

28th of Gloamreach,
468 AE

The waterways expand
and meander through
the Gardens. Districts
grow along the canals.
Paths align to form
the Six-Key Sigil
when oriented to
true north.



KEY NOTES

- + Paths form the Six-Key Sigil
- + Waterways now meander throughout
- + Districts established along the canals
- + Major structures near completion



GRAND ATRIUM
(Early Construction)

TRUE NORTH



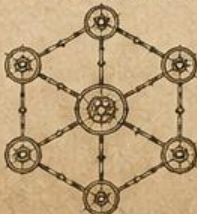
ARCHIVAL REFERENCE ONLY
DO NOT REMOVE
FROM RECORDS



SURVEY NOTES

- ✦ All surveys conducted from elevated observation towers.
- ✦ No evidence of recent construction or disruption between observations.
- ✦ Garden self-reconfigures according to unknown mechanisms.
- ✦ Ground level at time of Survey I. Elevation structures not yet present.

PATH ALIGNMENT KEY (Survey III)



When oriented to True North, the primary paths form the Six-Key Sigil.

ELEVATION SCALE

120 ft
90 ft
60 ft
30 ft

Ground (Survey I)



The Academy of Invention

Aetherhaven's foremost institution of engineering and discovery.

Its students study mechanics, chemistry, navigation, aether science and "responsible experimental enthusiasm." The Academy encourages creative thinking but strictly forbids research into conscious machines.

Despite this prohibition, someone has been using a sealed laboratory beneath the Hall of Unfinished Ideas.

Students occasionally see light beneath its door.

The Aether Gauntlet
 — Exterior Study

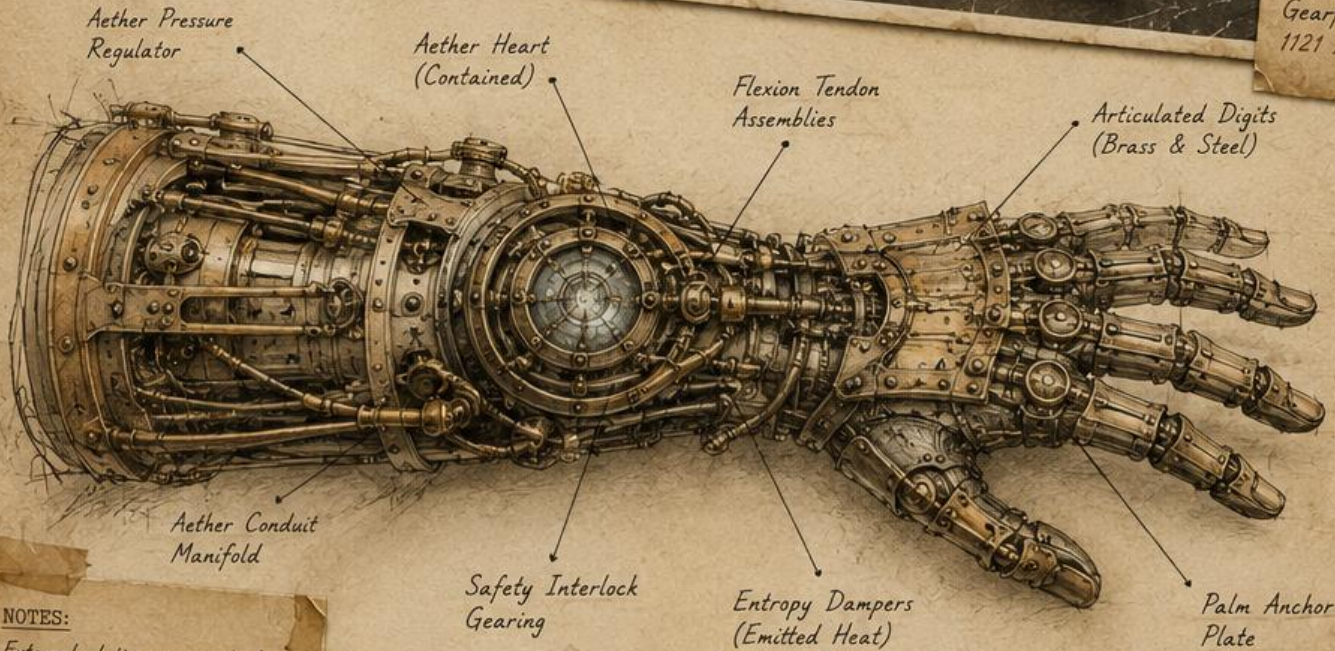
Primary interface and
 receptacle for the Aether Heart.
 Designed and constructed by
 Prof. Elias Hawthorne for his
 daughter, Amelia Hawthorne.
 Purpose: Channel, protect, and
 amplify Aetheric power through
 precision mechanisms.



"It is not merely a machine,
 but a bridge between
 flesh and force." — E.H.

DATE:

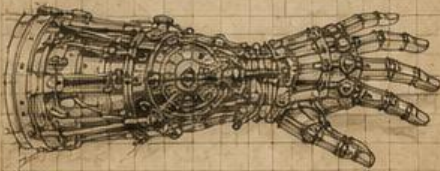
3rd of
 Gearfall,
 1121 A.H.



NOTES:

External plating composed of
 layered brass, tempered steel,
 and unknown alloy (see below).
 Decorative filigree removed
 from final construction at
 Amelia's request.

GAUNTLET - RIGHT ARM -
 LATERAL ELEVATION



AETHER HEART HOUSING



ELBOW JOINT ASSEMBLY

MATERIAL SAMPLE (UNKNOWN ALLOY)



Non-magnetic.
 Warm to touch.
 Resonates faintly
 when exposed to
 Aether frequencies.

— E.H.

PROF. HAWTHORNE'S ADDITIONS:

Reinforce thumb abductor.
 Improve heat dissipation along dorsal conduits.
 Add secondary lock to wrist housing.
 Ensure no sharp edges near wearer.

E. Hawthorne



The Eight Founding Engineering Guilds

The Eight Founding Engineering Guilds are the original human institutions credited with making early Aetherhaven livable after the discovery of the Aetherium.

Each accepted stewardship of one essential civic discipline:

- structure,
- motion,
- aetheric power,
- water,
- aerial engineering,
- timekeeping,
- precision mechanisms,
- and living machinery.

Together, the Eight represent modern Aetherhaven's attempt to impose understandable order upon mechanisms far older than the city itself.

They are not merely professional societies. Their apprenticeships, safety traditions, archives, rivalries, and technical standards shaped Aetherhaven's bridges, engines, canals, airships, clocks, automata, gardens, and public infrastructure.

The founding orders are:

1. The Guild of Framewrights
2. The Guild of Enginewrights
3. The Guild of Aetherwrights
4. The Guild of Canalwrights
5. The Guild of Skywrights
6. The Guild of Clockwrights
7. The Guild of Artificers
8. The Guild of Verdant Mechanists

In the modern city, the Eight retain their individual identities while operating within the larger **Mechanists' Guild**. Their guildmasters form the **Conclave of Eight**, which meets in the **Octagonal Hall** to advise on engineering law, public safety, major construction, and the certification of new machinery.

Their symbolism is deeply woven into Aetherhaven:

- **Six** belongs to the ancient world—the Six Keys, hidden locks, and the Heart Engine.
- **Eight** belongs to human Aetherhaven—labor, stewardship, civic order, and engineering.
- **Nine** suggests knowledge erased, excluded, or forbidden.

Official history teaches that the Eight gathered around the Aetherium and built the city together.

Whether there was once another discipline—one deliberately removed from the founding order—remains an uncomfortable question.

The Mechanists' Guild

The Mechanists' Guild is Aetherhaven's professional order governing engineers, repair workers, automata builders, engine operators, structural specialists, canal engineers, aether technicians, clockmakers, artificers, and other certified practitioners responsible for the city's machinery and infrastructure.

It is not one of the Eight Founding Engineering Guilds. It is the modern federation that unites them.

The Guild establishes common safety standards, certifies professional rank, investigates major mechanical failures, manages apprenticeships, mediates disputes between disciplines, and approves nearly every major machine connected to Aetherhaven's public systems.

Its members carry brass medallions engraved with their founding guild, certified specialty, rank, and right to practice. Older medallions are less standardized, and some contain a second symbol hidden beneath the official seal.

That concealed mark matches conduit patterns and architectural forms found inside the Heart Engine.

No current Guild record explains whether the founders copied the design without understanding it—or whether the medallions once served another purpose.

The Conservancy of Living Mechanisms

The Conservancy of Living Mechanisms is a pacifist fellowship of gardeners, botanists, healers, and mechanists responsible for caring for the Clockwork Gardens and the living machines that dwell within them.

Its members believe mechanical and living systems are not opposites, but expressions of the same natural order. They cultivate flowers that respond to music, restore clockwork creatures that develop distinct personalities, and care for roots, gears, insects, trees, pumps, and aetheric organisms as members of one interdependent community.

The Conservancy is gentle, eccentric, and deeply devoted to its work.

Its members avoid violence and carry no conventional weapons. They prefer patience, care, negotiation, and retreat. Yet their pacifism is not passivity. When the Gardens—or another living system under their protection—is threatened, they act immediately and with remarkable coordination.

Their defenses favor concealment, restraint, disorientation, sleep, immobilization, separation, and removal rather than injury.

Only a few outsiders understand what the Conservancy can awaken within the Gardens or how far its members will go to protect those in their care.

Its oldest rule states:

“Never allow the Gardens to recognize you as an intruder.”

Every Conservancy member learns the rule. No current member knows what happens if they fail.

CATALOG No. *AH-1-006*

SPECIMEN:

Dream Blossom
(*Somnum flos aetheris*)

ORIGIN:

Elderglen Garden
Recovered 12th of Emberfall, 447 AE

*Petals exude a
mild aetheric
resonance at
dusk and dawn.*



FIELD NOTES:

*The Dream Blossom opens only when
exposed to residual dream aether.
Its innards mirror the gearing
and regulators of the Heart Engine.
The connection is no coincidence.*

Fig. V. Petal Detail
(Surface)



*Microscopic
aether channels
along petal
veins.*



Fig. I. Entire Bloom

Fig. II. Longitudinal Section
(Bloom)

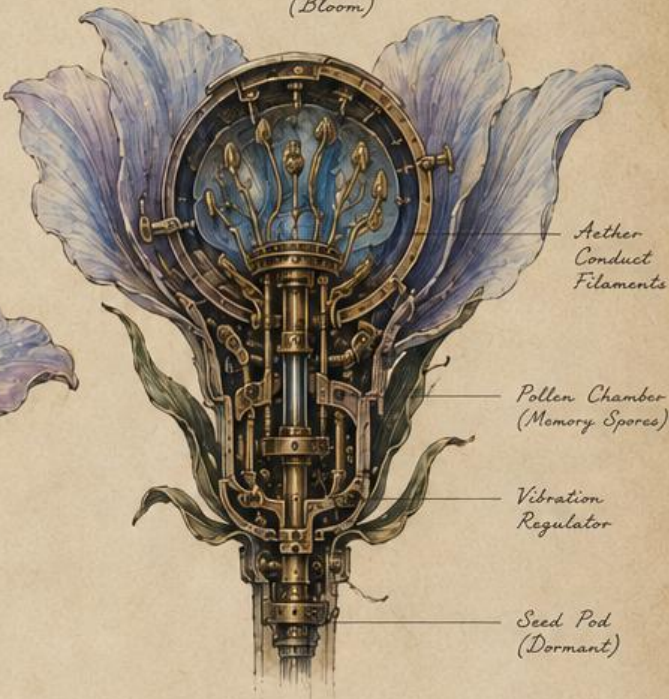


Fig. III.
Pollen Chamber
(Magnified)



*Memory spores
retain echo of
dream-state.*

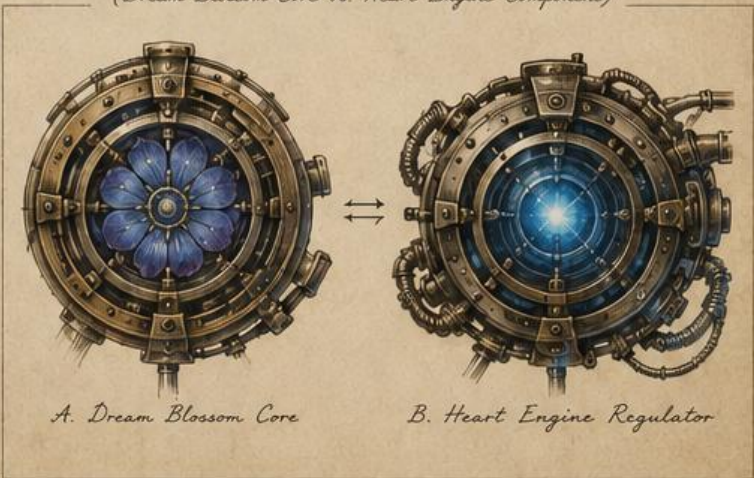
Fig. IV.
Seed Pod Section
(Dormant State)



*Encased in
protective
aetheric
membrane.*

*Reacts to
Heart Engine
frequency.*

Fig. VII. Mechanical Anatomy Comparison
(Dream Blossom Core vs. Heart Engine Component)



A. Dream Blossom Core

B. Heart Engine Regulator

ARCHIVAL BOTANICAL STUDY

Drawn by: Archivist L. Vance

Medium: Hand-colored Lithograph

Date: 18th of Emberfall, 447 AE



ARCHIVAL REFERENCE ONLY
DO NOT REMOVE FROM RECORDS

The Brass Watch

The Brass Watch is Aetherhaven's constabulary, emergency service, investigative authority, canal patrol, and first-response organization for temporal and other anomalous incidents.

Its officers patrol streets, waterways, public buildings, industrial districts, and restricted sites with the assistance of clockwork sentinels. Most Watch officers are honorable people trying to protect a city whose laws were written for ordinary crime but whose deepest dangers rarely behave ordinarily.

The Watch has responded to temporal irregularities for generations. It can secure a scene, evacuate civilians, compare conflicting records, preserve physical evidence, interview witnesses, synchronize clocks, and prevent an anomaly from spreading into public panic. These procedures are useful and often save lives.

They are also superficial.

The Watch knows how to manage the visible consequences of Aetherhaven's shifting chronology, but it does not understand the Heart Engine, the Lost Seconds, choral anchors, altered records, or the ancient command systems beneath the city. A case marked **resolved** usually means the location is stable and no longer immediately dangerous.

It does not mean the mystery was solved.

Chief Inspector Beatrice Thorne increasingly understands this distinction. She has seen evidence that survives official correction, records that change after filing, and structures that exist in one chronology but not another. She suspects the Watch has spent generations closing cases that were never truly closed.

The organization is waiting for breakthroughs it does not yet know it needs.

Those breakthroughs will increasingly come through the Hawthornes:

- Elias can interpret mechanisms the Watch mistakes for damaged infrastructure.
- Amelia can perceive and activate evidence inaccessible to Watch instruments.
- The Aether Heart can reveal choral residue, hidden commands, and ancient interfaces.
- The Watch provides the authority, records, witnesses, containment, and civic protection the Hawthornes lack.

The Watch will not become helpless without them. Its role is to grow from an institution that manages anomalies into one capable of genuinely investigating them. The sentinels, however, refuse to enter the Old City after midnight. Their command systems record the area as:

"Occupied by a higher authority."

AETHERHAVEN ARCHIVES

ARTIFACT FILE

CATALOG No. AH-1-005



DESIGNATION:

Prototype II

CLASSIFICATION:

*Mechanist Prosthesis
(Experimental)*

ORIGIN:

Aetherhaven Arsenal

DATE OF RECOVERY:

12th of Emberfall, 447 AE

RECOVERED BY:

Archivist L. Vance

CONDITION:

*Good - Minor surface wear,
components intact*

OBSERVATIONS:

*Photograph taken after disturbance
of display case.*

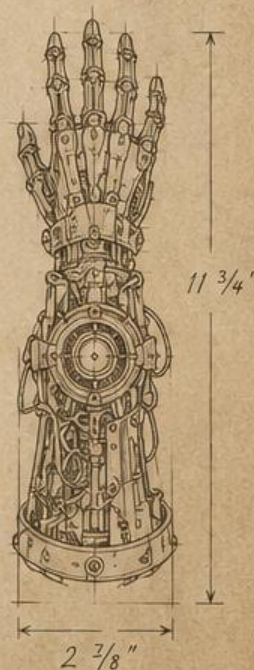
Seal found broken.

Dust pattern suggests recent handling.

*No signs of forced entry
to Arsenal wing.*

Aether Heart core active.

Investigations ongoing.



ARCHIVAL REFERENCE ONLY
DO NOT REMOVE FROM RECORDS

The Lamplighters' Fellowship

The Lamplighters' Fellowship maintains Aetherhaven's thousands of streetlamps, bridge lights, canal markers, public stair lamps, and aerial beacons.

Its members are ordinary working people—lamp tenders, wick cutters, fuel carriers, glass cleaners, ladder crews, night-route mechanics, and beacon keepers. They travel through nearly every district at hours when most of Aetherhaven is asleep.

Because of this, they notice things few others see:

- windows glowing inside abandoned buildings,
- doors that appear only after midnight,
- clandestine meetings beneath bridge lamps,
- people arriving before they were seen leaving,
- and streets that are longer at night than during the day.

The Fellowship does not consider itself an intelligence service. Its members rarely investigate what they witness and often have little interest in explaining it. They record practical details, remember what happened, finish their routes, and continue serving the city.

They hold no formal allegiance to the High Council, Brass Watch, Underclock, Society of Explorers, or any other faction.

A Lamplighter may nevertheless share what they saw when approached respectfully—especially when someone is missing, endangered, or trying to find the way home.

Their traditional greeting is:

"Keep a light for those still coming home."

A lamp has burned continuously inside Lamplighters' Hall for an explorer who vanished ninety-three years ago. Its flame was always gold. It has recently turned blue.

The Aerial Mariners' Union

The Aerial Mariners' Union represents the captains, navigators, dockworkers, riggers, engineers, weather readers, couriers, and routekeepers who keep Aetherhaven connected to the skies.

Its members guide ships through mountain winds, aether storms, cloud banks, uncertain borders, and routes that do not always behave the same way twice. The Union maintains rescue crews, certifies experienced mariners, supports injured workers and lost crews' families, and preserves generations of navigational knowledge unavailable in official government charts.

Its most important records are the **Living Charts**: privately maintained route maps corrected by hand after every unusual voyage. They show wind currents, pressure lanes, safe altitudes, and recurring aerial paths that do not appear on High Council maps.

Some of those currents should not exist.

The Union is politically powerful because nearly all aerial trade depends on its members. When it declares a **Closed Sky**, captains refuse departure, riggers leave the towers, engineers shut down launch systems, and dockworkers stop cargo movement. Aetherhaven's aerial commerce can slow to silence within hours.

The Union quietly enforces one rule more strictly than any public regulation:

"No member vessel may steer by the Returning Star."

The star appears above the Shattered Lands on certain nights. Ships that follow it sometimes vanish. Others return decades before they departed. The Union publicly calls the prohibition a navigation-safety measure. Its senior chartkeepers know it is something more.

Mysterious Figures

The First Mechanist

The legendary engineer credited with discovering—or constructing—the Heart Engine.

Historical records disagree about whether the First Mechanist was a man, a woman, a group of inventors or something that merely assumed a human shape.

Messages signed by the First Mechanist occasionally emerge from the city's pneumatic tubes.

The paper is always fresh.

The instructions are always accurate.

The handwriting matches the inscription hidden inside Amelia's arm.

The First Mechanist's Mark

Maker's mark attributed to the First Mechanist, legendary architect of the Heart Engine and creator of the Six Keys.

Found on machines, structures, documents, and stone throughout Aetherhaven and beneath.

DATE DISCOVERED:
17th of Bearsfire, 1023 A.H.

LOCATION:
Echoing Depths, Null Zone
Sector F-12

RECOVERED BY:
Prof. Elias Hawthorne

CONDITION:
Worn but consistent.
Surface encrusted with
mineral growth.

"The First Mechanist left no name,
only patterns that build and endure."
- E.H.



RUBBING TAKEN ON SITE

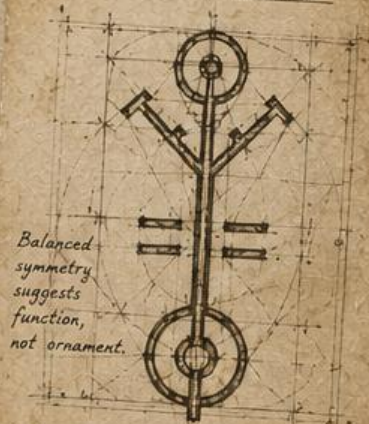
Depth of mark: 1.7mm
Tool pattern: rotating
cutter, 6-point array

AETHERHAVEN ARCHIVES
ACCESSION LABEL

CLASSIFICATION: Foundational Artifact
SUBJECT: Maker's Mark
MATERIAL: Unknown Alloy / Stone
DIMENSIONS: Varies
ACCESS LEVEL: **RESTRICTED**
ARCHIVIST: E. Hawthorne
DATE FILED: 1123 A.H.



ARCHIVIST SKETCH



Balanced
symmetry
suggests
function,
not ornament.

Likely used as both
signature and alignment
reference in ancient
mechanisms.

EARLIEST DOCUMENTED APPEARANCE



Entrance to Old City maintenance
tunnel. Dated: approx. 412 A.H.
Stone predates current street level.

EXAMPLES FOUND ACROSS AETHERHAVEN



Heart Engine Support Brace Grand Atrium Gear Housing Pneumatic Message Capsule Sixth Door Frame

PROF. HAWTHORNE'S FIELD SKETCH



Repeated in places
that predate the
Heart Engine
construction.

Coincidence
unlikely.

May indicate network
of older systems...
...or a builder who
planned far ahead.

PROVENANCE NOTES



Recovered during Null Zone
excavation. Mark present on
substructure component at
approx. 27m below current
Aetherhaven depth.

FRAGMENTARY TEXT (TRANSLITERATION)

⌘⌘⌘⌘⌘⌘⌘⌘⌘⌘
⌘⌘⌘⌘⌘⌘⌘⌘⌘⌘

TRANSLATION ATTEMPT (INCOMPLETE)

"Maker... builder...
Measure... balance...
Cycle without end...
By design, not by chance.
- ? -

Line 3 uncertain,
Symbol appears between
lines 2 and 3 in original.

ARCHIVIST OBSERVATIONS

The mark appears on items of extraordinary age and purpose.
Never found on anything mass-produced in recent centuries.
Hypothesis: Not merely a maker's mark, but
or attunement sequence.

FURTHER STUDY
RECOMMENDED

RELATED FILES

AH-1-002 The Six-Key Sigil
AH-1-009 Heart Engine Architectures
AH-1-044 Prototype II Comparative Study

CLASSIFIED
BY ORDER OF THE HIGH COUNCIL

CLASSIFIED

The Lady in the Water

A woman sometimes seen in the Reflection Canals. She appears only in reflections and never directly.

She resembles an older version of Amelia, although her mechanical arm is composed of silver-white material rather than brass.

She has spoken only once:

“Do not let him open the sixth door.”

No one knows whom she meant.

Keeper Thirteen

An unknown figure associated with the Clocktower Spire.

Whenever the tower strikes thirteen, a tall person in a dark coat can sometimes be seen walking through one of its temporary doors. No facial features are visible beneath the figure's hood.

Keeper Thirteen has repeatedly intervened to save citizens from disasters before they occur.

Yet every person rescued loses one specific memory.

The Ashen Cartographer

A masked traveler who leaves maps in abandoned rooms, sealed vaults and places no one has yet explored.

The maps are drawn in ash and cannot be erased. They often show secret routes, but following them always requires the traveler to surrender something meaningful.

The Cartographer's newest map depicts the interior of Amelia's mechanical arm.

At its center is a room.

CATALOG No. AH-1-007

The Changing Paths of the Gardens

Three surveys of the Elderlen Garden, recorded across different cycles. The layout of the paths is not consistent between observations. When aligned to true north, the arrangement of the third survey forms the Six-Key Sigil.



Observation I

12th of Emberfall, 447 AE

Paths meander freely.
No discernible pattern
beyond natural growth.



Observation III

3rd of Thalendorn, 448 AE

Paths realigned since
previous observation.
Cause unknown.



Observation III

28th of Gloamreach, 448 AE

Paths form the Six-Key
Sigil when aligned to
true north.

Intentional pattern
suspected.



SURVEY NOTES:

All surveys conducted from the Academy spire
using aether-lens elevation.
No evidence of recent construction or disruption
between observations.
Garden self-reconfigures.



ARCHIVAL REFERENCE ONLY
DO NOT REMOVE FROM RECORDS

The Passenger of Dock Zero

The Passenger of Dock Zero is a solitary, unidentified traveler who repeatedly waits near the sealed hangar at the Aerial Docks and the permanently reserved Morningstar berth at the Gardens' Airship Landing. His identity is unknown to the High Council, and he offers no reliable account of his name, origin, or destination.

He wears the weathered uniform of an airship line that does not appear in any surviving registry. The cut, fastenings, and insignia are internally consistent enough to suggest a real organization, but no Harbormaster, archivist, commercial captain, or Aerial Mariners' Union official has identified it.

Captain Mara Voss found an ornate Morningstar passage ticket in his possession after he made repeated attempts to enter the reserved berth. The ticket's passenger field had been blurred, abraded, or otherwise damaged. Several remaining strokes appear compatible with the Passenger's claim that the ticket belongs to him, but not enough survives to verify his name or identity.

The ticket was impounded for verification and transferred to the Aetherhaven Archives under restricted transit review. Its encoded departure notation belongs to an obsolete Upper Strata transit concordance. Mara and the city's chronologers interpret it as a departure window approximately forty-seven years beyond the current civic year, though the exact conversion varies as Aetherhaven's timekeeping systems drift.

The Passenger does not appear to understand the ticket as being dated decades in the future.

He is impatient, urgent, secretive, and exceptionally persistent, but he is not violent or belligerent. He has committed no crime serious enough to justify imprisonment. The Brass Watch has questioned him repeatedly, yet his answers remain incomplete, contradictory, or strangely detached from the questions being asked.

At times he seems deliberately evasive. At other times he appears genuinely confused, as though he remembers that he must leave Aetherhaven but has forgotten why. He returns regularly and asks the same question:

“Has the *Morningstar* arrived yet?”

When told that it has not, he appears relieved.

THE PASSENGER'S
FUTURE-DATED TICKET

There are tickets
that do not summon—
but remember.
—M.V.

Status: *Impounded for Verification*

Holding Authority:
Harbormaster's Office

Officer:
Captain Mara Voss

Current Custody:
Aetherhaven Archives —
Restricted Transit Review



EVIDENCE SEAL No. 77A
DO NOT OPEN

UPPER STRATA PASSAGE TICKET

MORNINGSTAR

— AIRSHIP PASSAGE —

PASSENGER: *E. Hanger*

CLASS: STRATA CABIN — OBSERVATORY

DEPARTURE CONCORDANCE CODE:

USC-79 / Ember Sequence 499 /
Return Alignment VII

TICKET No.
MS-7-0-499

VALID ONLY FOR STATED CONCORDANCE WINDOW
SUBJECT TO UPPER STRATA NAVIGATIONAL LAW

BERTH
RESERVATION

7-0

ZERO DOCK



ADM. CLERK

L. Marrow

RECOVERED: DOCK ZERO
DATE: 17TH DAY OF COGSREACH, CY 998

ARCHIVIST NOTE:

This ticket was found in the possession of the individual known as the Passenger of Dock Zero after repeated attempts to access the reserved Morningstar berth.

OBSERVATION: BEARER PROFILE

- *Impatient.*
- *Secretive.*
- *Persistent.*
- *Not violent.*
- *Identity unknown to the High Council.*



TRANSIT CODE INTERPRETATION

The obsolete Upper Strata transit code (USC-79 / Ember Sequence 499 / Return Alignment VII) has been interpreted by the Concordance Office as indicating a departure window approximately *forty-seven (47) years* in Aetherhaven's future, relative to the current civic year (CY 998).

PASSENGER OF DOCK ZERO



DOCK LOG EXCERPT — HARBORMASTER'S OFFICE

CY 998 / 17th of Cogsreach
Passenger presented ticket for berth 7-0 (Morningstar).
Informed vessel not present. Ticket impounded for verification.
He accepted reluctantly.

CY 998 / 19th of Cogsreach
Passenger returned. Asked: "Has the Morningstar arrived yet?"
Informed again: not present.
Observation: He appeared relieved.

CY 998 / 22nd of Cogsreach
Passenger returned. Asked same question.
Informed again: not present. He sighed—relief apparent.
No threats. No disturbance.



RESERVED BERTH MARKER



Marker exists at the Gardens' Airship Landing.
No current vessel registry entry matches the name "Morningstar."

REVERSE SIDE RUBBING & WATERMARK STUDY



Laid paper with
embedded starburst
watermark and
faint countermark
"M.C." within
compass.

Indicates connection
to Morningstar
Company stock,
not conclusive.

CATALOG NOTE / ARCHIVIST SUMMARY

No authenticated vessel named "Morningstar" appears in current municipal or commercial registries of Aetherhaven.

Yet the name persists—on this ticket, on the reserved berth marker at the Gardens' Airship Landing, and on cargo or crate emblems attributed to the Morningstar Company.

The implications remain uncertain.



The Null Shepherd

A child-sized figure seen walking through the Null Zone, surrounded by silent mechanical animals.

Machines fail in the Null Zone, yet the Shepherd's companions move without difficulty. The figure has never approached the city.

After Amelia entered the region, the Shepherd began building something from black stones.

From above, the structure resembles the Hawthorne family crest.

The Bellmaker

An elderly artisan whom no one remembers meeting, though bells bearing his mark can be found throughout Aetherhaven.

His bells do not announce hours. They ring when particular events occur: the breaking of an oath, the awakening of an ancient machine or the arrival of someone who should not exist.

A tiny bell appeared inside Amelia's satchel after her first visit to the Grand Atrium.

It has never rung.

The Stillmaker

The whispered strategist of the Severed Coil

Among the rumors surrounding the Severed Coil, no name is spoken more carefully than **the Stillmaker**.

Some believe the Stillmaker is the faction's hidden commander. Others insist the title belongs to a succession of leaders, a council of extremists, or perhaps no living person at all. The Coil's decentralized cells rarely know who directs operations beyond their immediate handler, and captured members offer contradictory accounts.

What remains consistent is the reputation.

The Stillmaker is said to plan attacks with unnatural patience, arranging small failures months or even years before their purpose becomes clear. Clocks stop shortly before the Stillmaker's operations begin. Instructions sometimes arrive before the events that prompted them. Targets are chosen not merely for destruction, but for the fear, suspicion, and political reaction their loss will create.

Unlike the Severed Coil's more impulsive radicals, the Stillmaker does not appear to seek chaos for its own sake. Every disrupted canal, severed conduit, stolen sentinel, or burned record is believed to serve a larger design—one the Brass Watch has not yet understood.

No verified witness has described the Stillmaker's face.

No officer has proven where the orders originate.

And no captured operative agrees on whether the Stillmaker gives commands directly.

The only phrase repeatedly associated with the name is found in coded messages and beside mechanisms deliberately brought to a halt:

"Before the city can be freed, it must first be made still."

To the citizens of Aetherhaven, the Stillmaker is less a person than a warning: evidence that behind the Severed Coil's scattered violence, someone may be listening to the city's clocks—and waiting for the precise moment to stop them.

Hidden and Forbidden Organizations

The Ninth Guild

Official records recognize only eight founding engineering guilds.

The Ninth Guild appears on no charter, membership roll, or accepted civic history. Nevertheless, singular devices bearing the **Black Lacuna** continue to surface throughout Aetherhaven—particularly in hidden institutional spaces and the illicit workshops of the Cauldron.

The Guild does not manufacture machines in vast factories. It revises them.

Its members recover forbidden research, complete abandoned prototypes, graft memories into mechanisms, awaken conscious automata, and transform existing inventions into forms their creators never intended.

No two Ninth Guild devices are alike. Every one is an experiment. Every one has a history.

Some members are criminals seeking wealth, leverage, or power. Others are expelled scholars, physicians, mechanists, archivists, and former Academy researchers who believe the High Council and recognized guilds have destroyed discoveries essential to humanity's future.

The Ninth Guild does not claim to be merely another engineering trade. It claims the Eight Founding Guilds were constructed around an absence—and that the empty center of the Octagonal Hall marks knowledge deliberately removed from Aetherhaven's history.

Its hidden leader is known as **the Curator**, keeper of the distributed Black Catalogue.

The Curator teaches:

"Nothing discovered should ever be lost."

The Guild's greatest danger is not that it hates humanity. It is that it considers memory, identity, consciousness, and even human lives forms of knowledge that may be preserved, transferred, revised, and catalogued without consent.

The Order of the Closed Eye

The Order of the Closed Eye is a secret society believed to operate within the High Council, Academy of Invention, Society of Explorers, Mechanists' Guild, civic Archives, and other powerful institutions throughout Aetherhaven.

Its members believe certain discoveries become dangerous simply by being understood. A translated inscription, restored memory, completed map, or correctly recognized symbol may function as a key capable of awakening an ancient mechanism.

To prevent such activations, the Order conceals artifacts, alters maps, seals laboratories, fragments records, and removes dangerous knowledge through a process it calls **Closure**.

Its symbol is a closed mechanical eye, often marked with a tiny keyhole at its center.

Some credit the Order with preventing catastrophes the public will never know came close to occurring. Others accuse it of quietly deciding which truths Aetherhaven is permitted to remember.

The Order may have protected the city for generations.

It may also exert far more control over the High Council than the Council itself realizes—and may be the reason no one remembers what truly happened during the expedition that changed Amelia's arm.



AETHERHAVEN ARCHIVES

ARTIFACT CATALOG SLIP

CATALOG NO.
AH-1-014

RECORD TYPE:
MECHANICAL PROTOTYPE

TITLE: PROTOTYPE I (HEART ENGINE EXPERIMENTAL UNIT)

OBJECT CLASS: AETHERIC MECHANISM

ORIGIN: ACADEMY OF INVENTION
Clockwork Gardens, Aetherhaven

STATUS:

MISSING

REMOVED FROM COLLECTION
AND OFFICIAL RECORDS

DESCRIPTION (AS RECORDED)

First experimental unit of the Heart Engine project. Designed to test aetheric resonance stability within a self-contained mechanical core.

Details of construction and aetherium integration were classified under Academy Seal. Further notes removed.



PHOTOGRAPH (ORIGINAL)
(Now Removed)

DATE CATALOGED:
7th of Spirefall, 452 AE

CATALOGED BY:
Archivist L. Maren
Academy Curator

ACCESSION No.

~~23-30-33~~

CROSS REFERENCES:
AH-1-010, AH-1-011,
AH-1-013, AH-1-015

NOTES FROM INVENTOR LOG

Prototype I responded to resonance... but not in the manner predicted. Instability event - brief, violent, then silence.

I was ordered to cease all work and surrender the unit to the Academy.

They said it was for everyone's safety.

I believe they were afraid of what it understood.

- E. Hawthorne

CATALOG NOTES

Prototype I was the earliest full-scale iteration of the Heart Engine. Its current location is unknown.

~~All technical schematics, blueprints, and related materials have been removed from the Archive under Council Directive VII-19.~~

BY ORDER OF THE HIGH COUNCIL
THIS RECORD HAS BEEN ALTERED.
ANY FURTHER INQUIRY IS TREASON.



RECORD HISTORY

452 AE Initial Cataloging
452 AE Restricted Access
457 AE Documentation Redacted
459 AE Item Removed
459 AE Records Altered
459 AE All References Sealed

ACADEMY CATALOG INDEX MECHANICAL DIVISION

AH-1-012	Prototype II	✓
AH-1-013	Aetherium Core	✓
AH-1-014	Prototype I	✗
AH-1-015	Auxiliary Regulator Array	✓

Array

CONDITION (AS LAST RECORDED)

Structural Integrity: Unknown
Aetheric Stability: Unstable
Operational Status: Unknown
Last Known State: Post-Instability Event
Notes: Unit removed before final assessment.

HANDLING INSTRUCTIONS (REDACTED)

~~REDACTED~~
~~REDACTED~~
~~REDACTED~~
~~REDACTED~~

The Custodians of the Six Keys

An ancient fellowship charged with keeping six Aether Keys separated.

According to fragmented records, bringing the Keys together could awaken the Heart Engine's true purpose. Some Custodians believe this would save the world. Others believe it would end it.

The fellowship fractured generations ago.

At least one faction believes Amelia herself is one of the Keys.

CATALOG No. AH-1-002

The Six-Key Sigil

Ancient symbol discovered carved into basalt slab beneath debris field in the Null Zone, Sector F-12. Associated with references to the "Six Keys" in early Aetherhaven texts. Purpose unknown.

DATE DISCOVERED:

3rd of Gearfall, 1128 A.H.

LOCATION:

Null Zone, Sector F-12

RECOVERED BY:

Prof. Elias Hawthorne

CONDITION:

Fragmented but stable.
Surface encrusted
with mineral growth.

PROF. HAWTHORNE'S NOTES

Found 6 recesses arranged with perfect symmetry. Central mechanism appears designed to accept six separate keys. Unknown if keys are literal, symbolic, or something else entirely.

- E.H.



FIELD TAG

F-12-77B

BASALT RUBBING



Rubbing taken on site before slab was moved.

DETAIL: ONE RECESS



Edges beveled inward.
No signs of wear.
Never used?

ARCHIVIST SKETCH (RECONSTRUCTION)



Proportions exact. Symbols translated from fragmentary text.

FRAGMENTARY TEXT (TRANSLITERATION)

𐌺𐌰 𐌹 𐌰 𐌺 𐌰 𐌰
𐌺𐌰 𐌰 𐌰 𐌰 𐌰 𐌰

PARTIAL TRANSLATION

"...six guardians... six remember...
when the circle is complete,
the heart below will wake..."

EXCAVATION PHOTOGRAPH



Slab embedded in collapse layer
approx. 27 meters below surface.

KEY OBSERVATIONS

- Six recesses align with ancient "Six-Key" references.
- Central lock rotates freely but does not open.
- Minor resonance detected when Aether Gauntlet in proximity.
- Further study required.

CONFIDENTIAL

The Morningstar Company

A trading company with no registered offices, employees or ships.

Its emblem appears on crates recovered from the fog-bound vessel at the Southern Docks. The contents vary: ancient machine parts, seeds from extinct plants and newspapers describing events that have not happened.

Every crate contains a delivery receipt.

All are signed by Elias Hawthorne.

The Quiet Choir

An underground network whose members communicate through vibrations carried in the city's pipes.

No one has seen its leaders. Some believe the Choir consists of workers and dissidents. Others suspect it is a collective intelligence formed by the city's oldest machines.

The messages are usually warnings.

Recently, every pipe beneath Aetherhaven carried the same words:

THE LITTLE KEY HAS AWAKENED.

The Obsidian Covenant

A group associated with the inaccessible Obsidian Spire.

Its agents wear polished black masks and rarely speak. They appear during major aether disturbances, collecting fragments and eliminating evidence.

The Covenant seems hostile to the Custodians of the Six Keys—but has repeatedly avoided harming Amelia when given the opportunity.

Its members do not call Amelia an enemy.

They call her **Her Majesty**.

The Underclock

The Underclock is a loose alliance of smugglers, canal runners, tunnel guides, sanctuary keepers, mechanics, couriers, and information brokers operating beneath and between Aetherhaven's recognized districts.

Unlike the Ninth Guild, it is not primarily malicious. Its members help people escape unjust authorities, transport forbidden books, recover confiscated property, shelter endangered witnesses, and navigate tunnels the official city no longer admits exist.

Its knowledge comes at a price, and its protection carries obligations. But once someone has been formally granted sanctuary, the Underclock does not sell them, reveal their refuge, or return them to the authority from which they fled.

The network has no confirmed leader or headquarters. It survives through local crews, safe houses, inherited keys, hidden routes, personal debts, and carefully divided information.

That decentralization is its greatest strength.

It is also its greatest weakness.

A person who controls the right fragment of information can manipulate one part of the Underclock without the rest understanding the larger operation—a vulnerability exploited when the Ninth Guild deceived an Underclock crew into helping remove Prototype I from the custody of the Order of the Closed Eye.

Tamsin Pike may already belong to the Underclock.

Or the Underclock may believe she belongs to it because of a route, promise, protection, or debt inherited through her family.

The Unwound

The Unwound is a broad reform movement united by one belief:

Dependence without understanding is surrender.

Its members argue that Aetherhaven has become dangerously dependent on the Heart Engine, the Golden Veins, synchronized civic clocks, automated sentinels, and machinery no living engineer fully understands.

The movement does not uniformly oppose machines.

Most Unwound members are artisans, workers, engineers, gardeners, canal keepers, teachers, and families who believe machines should remain comprehensible, repairable, interruptible, and accountable to the people who use them.

They teach handcraft, maintain manual pumps, build spring-driven backup systems, preserve unsynchronized clocks, and organize neighborhoods capable of surviving temporary failures of the city's aether network.

A radical splinter faction, known as **the Severed Coil**, has begun sabotaging Golden Veins and other critical systems. The High Council frequently uses those attacks to portray the entire movement as dangerous.

That portrayal is politically convenient and factually incomplete.

The Unwound may be wrong about some of the Heart Engine's purpose, but they are not wrong that Aetherhaven is feeding something.

The Severed Coil

The Severed Coil is the violent extremist splinter of the Unwound.

Where the broader Unwound argues that Aetherhaven must reduce its dependence on the Heart Engine, the Severed Coil believes the city must first be made to fail.

Its members attack Golden Veins, destroy civic machinery, sabotage power regulators, burn records, steal or corrupt clockwork sentinels, and create public disruption intended to prove that Aetherhaven cannot survive without systems its citizens do not understand.

They do not merely predict collapse.

They manufacture it.

The Severed Coil is deeply underground, organized through isolated cells, false names, coded broadsides, and intermediaries who often do not know whom they ultimately serve. Its true size, leadership, funding, and objectives remain unknown.

The faction is feared throughout Aetherhaven.

Citizens know it through:

- blackened open-coil symbols,
 - severed brass conduits,
 - anonymous warnings,
 - abandoned tools,
 - missing engineers,
 - damaged districts,
 - and the silence before a public system fails.
-

Appendix A – Uncategorized Assets

AETHERHAVEN ARCHIVES
ARTIFACT FILE

CATALOG No. *AH-1-006*

The Wayfinder

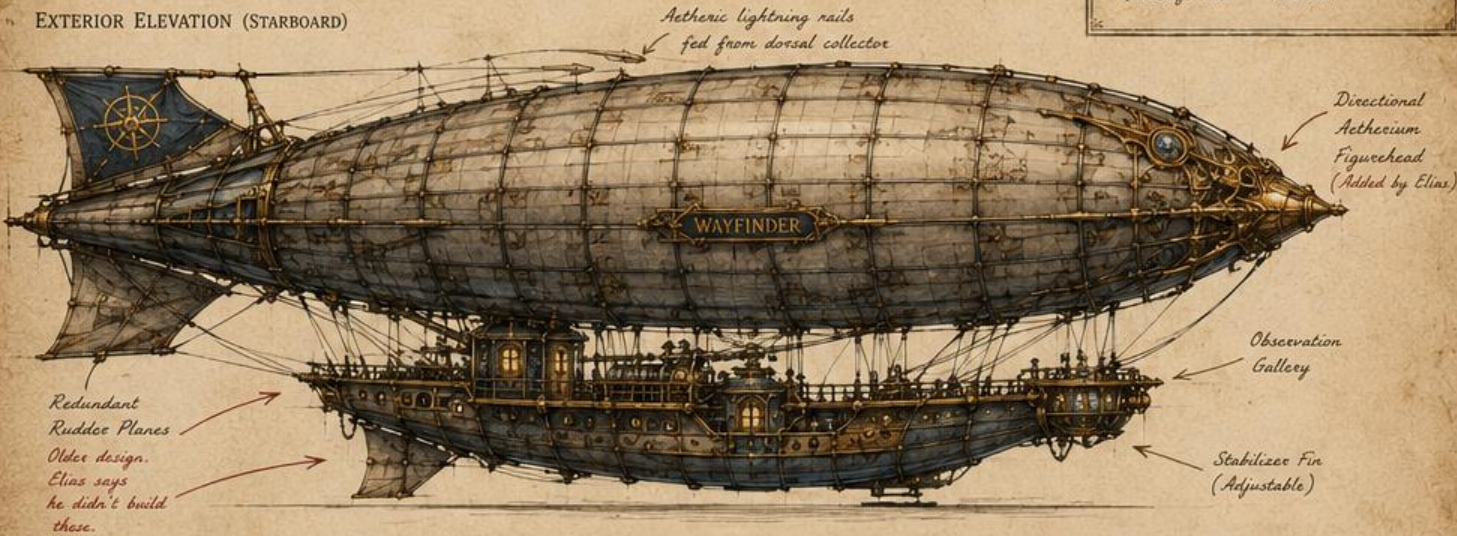
HAWTHORNE MODEL W-7A • EXPLORER CLASS AIRSHIP

"Not just a machine, but a companion."
She has carried us farther than any map." — A. Hawthorne

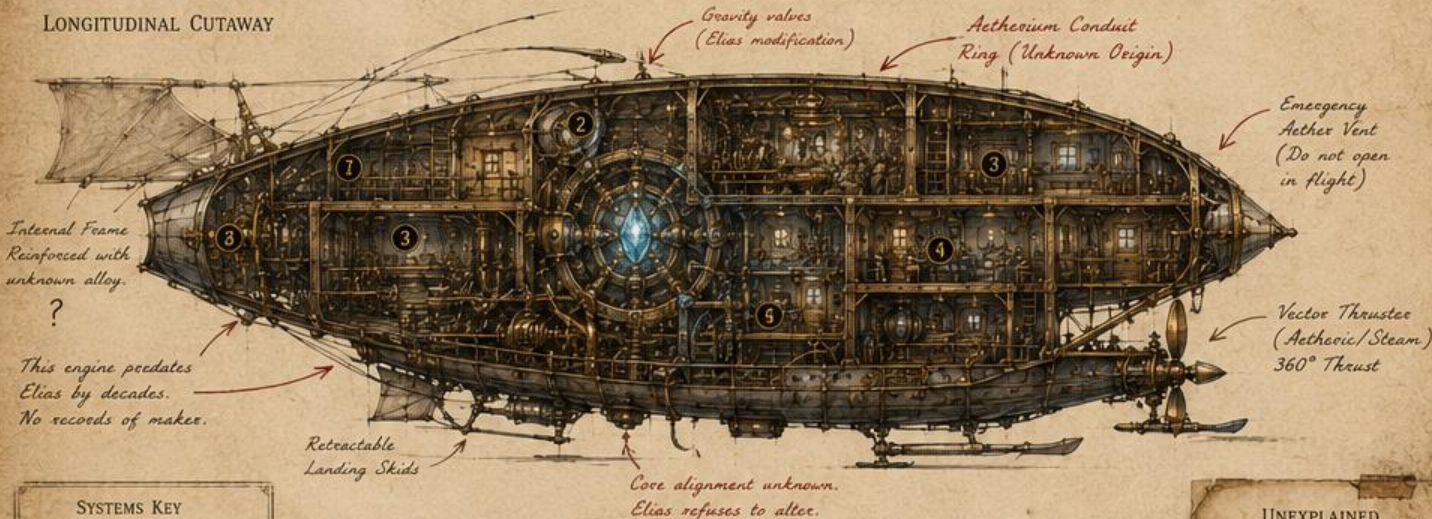
SPECIFICATIONS

Length: 167 ft.
Beam: 34 ft.
Height: 52 ft.
Displacement: 48,700 lbs.
Lift Capacity: ~32,000 lbs.
Crew: 6 (standard)
Aetherium Core: Heart Engine
Propulsion: Aetheric / Steam
Max Safe Alt: Unknown

EXTERIOR ELEVATION (STARBOARD)



LONGITUDINAL CUTAWAY



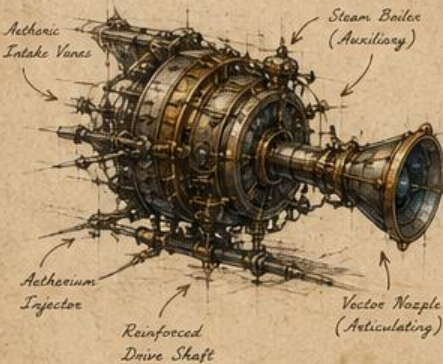
SYSTEMS KEY

- 1 Pilothouse & Aetheric Controls
- 2 Crew Quarters
- 3 Aetherium Core (Heart Engine)
- 4 Cargo Hold
- 5 Workshop & Fabrication Bay
- 6 Galley & Common Room
- 7 Observation Lounge
- 8 Aft Engine Room

NOTES FROM ELIAS' JOURNAL

She came to me half-built and full of secrets. Some parts resist my tools. Some respond to no tools at all. The old makers knew things we have forgotten.

PROPULSION DETAILS



MODIFICATIONS & REPAIRS
(By Amelia Hawthorne)

- ✓ Reinforced port casing (5th day of Highsun)
- ✓ Replaced starboard lamp (11th day of Highsun)
- ✓ Calibrated dorsal collector (13th day of Highsun)
- ✓ Patched envelope seam amidships (19th day of Highsun)
- ✓ Adjusted gravity valves (23rd day of Highsun)
- ✓ Rewired observation lounge console (27th day of Highsun)

She groans in the wind, but she never gives up. Neither do I. — A.H.

UNEXPLAINED COMPONENTS



Aetheric Resonance Crystal Array (Function Unknown)



Ancient Pressure Balance (No maker's mark)



Obsidian Coil Assembly (Dormant?)

ENVELOPE REPAIR LOG



AETHERIUM CORE STATUS

Last Calibration: 12th day of Highsun



Stability: 78%
Output: Nominal
Resonance: Variable
Warning: Core hum INCREASES NEAR STORMWALLS.

WARNINGS

- Do not alter Aetherium Conduit Ring.
- Opening Aether Vent in flight may cause catastrophic decompression.
- Vector Thrusters not rated for continuous operation.
- Unknown components may react to specific aether frequencies.

PROCEED WITH RESPECT.



Recommended Artifact Image Slate

To keep the material visually coherent, I would establish a recurring format called the **Aetherhaven Archival Plate**.

Most images should be created as **8 × 12-inch portrait plates**, matching the book’s current 2:3 format. Maps and large architectural studies can use **16 × 12-inch landscape spreads**. Each plate should feel assembled by an archivist from real recovered evidence: one principal artifact surrounded by annotations, photographs, rubbings, sketches, catalog tags, stains, folds, repairs, and occasional redactions.

The first production slate should concentrate on **Volume One: The Living Key**, while quietly introducing symbols that will matter in later volumes.

I. Foundational Canon Images

These establish the visual language of the entire series.

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
1	The Hawthorne Explorer’s Crest	Embossed brass seal, wax imprint, stitched expedition patch, and Elias’s handwritten variation	Establishes the Hawthorne family and the crest later found inside the Null Zone. It should include a compass rose, winged gear, lantern, and a subtle key motif.
2	Seal of the Society of Explorers	Official embossed seal beside a weathered expedition document	Appears on maps, field reports, artifact labels, and Elias’s credentials. Respectable on the surface, but one section of the seal should conceal an older symbol.
3	The Six-Key Sigil	Stone rubbing, brass medallion, charcoal tracing, and partial ancient inscription	The primary visual symbol of the larger saga: six keys or keyholes arranged around a central circular mechanism. It should not yet reveal precisely how the keys function.
4	The First Mechanist’s Mark	Engraving found beneath layers of oxidized metal	A simple but unmistakable maker’s mark that can recur on old machines, Amelia’s arm, hidden doors, and documents. It should feel ancient rather than decorative.
5	The Living Key Emblem	Illuminated manuscript fragment or ancient brass inlay	Similar to the Six-Key Sigil, but with one position represented by a living hand or branching mechanical vine. Its meaning should remain uncertain.
6	Canonical Aetherhaven Archive Label	Blank catalog plate with accession number, source, recovery location, condition, and classification stamps	This becomes the recurring graphic framework for artifact pages throughout the books.
7	The Wayfinder Technical Plate	Lithographic airship elevation, cutaway drawing, repair notes, and modifications in Amelia’s handwriting	Establishes the Hawthornes’ vessel as a character in its own right. Include several unexplained older components Elias did not build.

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
8	Professor Hawthorne's Field Journal	Open journal spread with pockets, fold-out map, pencil sketches, pressed flower, and coded notation	Establishes Elias's research style and provides a reusable source for later clues and interludes.

II. Amelia and the Aether Gauntlet

These should make the arm feel mysterious, evolving, and archaeologically significant—not merely like an inventor’s blueprint.

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
9	The Aether Gauntlet: Exterior Study	Detailed Academy lithograph with brass measurement tools and handwritten corrections	Shows gears, pistons, plates, pipes, pressure chambers, articulated fingers, and the embedded Aether Heart. Some components should be labeled “origin unknown.”
10	The Aether Gauntlet: Internal Cutaway	Cyanotype engineering study partially overlaid with an older parchment diagram	Reveals that Elias’s work follows a much older internal architecture, whether he knew it or not.
11	Prototype II Cabinet Photograph	Sepia archival photograph of the mechanical arm preserved inside the Academy	The label reads: PROTOTYPE II — AWAITING THE BEARER . Include evidence that the cabinet was recently opened.
12	The Missing Prototype I Catalog Card	Torn Academy catalog slip, empty photograph mounting corners, erased accession number	Confirms that Prototype I existed but has been removed from both the collection and official records.
13	Aether Gauntlet Activation Imprint	Burn pattern or luminous contact mark left on an ancient door	A recognizable hand-shaped symbol that appears whenever Amelia awakens dormant machinery.
14	Amelia’s Explorer Journal: First Mechanical Sketches	Child’s careful drawings mixed with increasingly sophisticated mechanical observations	Shows Amelia’s intelligence developing naturally. Include small personal observations that adults overlooked.

III. The Clockwork Gardens

These connect the existing garden artwork to the city’s deeper mythology.

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
15	Botanical Plate of the Dream Blossom	Hand-colored scientific lithograph with real and mechanical cross-sections	The flower from the first garden story. Its mechanical anatomy resembles part of the Heart Engine.
16	The Mechanical Firefly Specimen Sheet	Delicate ink study, wing diagrams, tiny gear components, and repair notes	Records the creature Amelia rescued. One annotation suggests it is far older than the Gardens.

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
17	The Grand Atrium Architectural Lithograph	Antique elevation and cutaway of the glass dome	Shows the central orrery, hidden maintenance passages, and one sealed doorway omitted from public plans.
18	The Changing Paths of the Gardens	Three maps of the same garden drawn on different dates	Demonstrates that the pathways physically rearrange themselves. One version forms the Six-Key Sigil when viewed from above.
19	Juniper Bell's Botanical Ledger	Pressed leaves, seed envelopes, insect sketches, and cryptic cultivation notes	Suggests Juniper understands the Gardens as one living intelligence. Dates in the ledger span more than two centuries.
20	The Unfamiliar Sky Panel	Photographic plate of the Atrium glass reflecting an impossible constellation	Supports the mystery of the midnight sky visible in one section of the dome.

IV. “The Thirteenth Canal”

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
21	Tamsin Pike's Brass Key	Scale photograph, wax imprint, metal rubbing, and handwritten family notes	The key should look worn from generations of handling and carry a symbol no one initially recognizes.
22	The Forbidden Canal Map	Water-damaged lockkeeper's map with twelve official canals and a hand-drawn thirteenth route	The thirteenth canal should pass beneath locations that should not physically connect.
23	Pike Bridge Lock Inscription	Stone rubbing with translated and untranslated lines	Contains Amelia's name or title in a script created centuries before her birth.
24	Underclock Passage Token	Blackened brass token, cord, coded edge marks, and charcoal handprint	Introduces the Underclock without fully explaining the organization.

V. “The Passenger of Dock Zero”

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
25	The Passenger's Future-Dated Ticket	Ornate punched airship ticket preserved beneath glass	Dated forty-seven years in the future and issued for passage aboard the <i>Morningstar</i> .
26	Dock Zero Restricted Photograph	Grainy sepia night photograph of the sealed hangar with its landing lights illuminated	The photograph should contain an indistinct figure and perhaps the outline of a ship that was not visible to witnesses.
27	The Morningstar Company Manifest	Cargo manifest with impossible items, unfamiliar ports, and Elias Hawthorne's signature	Elias denies signing it. The ink should be chemically recent.

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
28	Captain Mara Voss's Backward Clock	Cabinet photograph and repair diagram of a clock from the <i>Resolute</i>	Its internal mechanism runs normally, but its hands move backward and mark dates rather than hours.

VI. “The Bell Beneath the Clocktower”

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
29	The Bellmaker's Mark	Brass rubbing, maker's stamp, and examples found on unrelated bells	Establishes the symbol that appears across centuries with no record of the artisan who created it.
30	The Memory Bell	Dark photographic study of a small bell beside notes from affected witnesses	The bell rings when an important memory is removed or returned.
31	Clocktower Interior Gear Study	Dramatic lithographic cutaway showing impossible levels inside the tower	The tower's interior appears larger than its exterior dimensions allow.
32	Keeper Thirteen Witness Sketches	Several drawings by unrelated witnesses compiled on one police evidence sheet	Each drawing differs slightly, but all show the same coat, hood, and unusual pocket watch.

VII. “The Machine Behind the Wall”

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
33	Gearbreaker Excavation Photograph	Large sepia plate of miners standing before the smooth metal wall	Establishes the wall's enormous scale and six empty sockets. Amelia should not yet appear in the image.
34	The Six-Socket Wall Rubbing	Full archaeological rubbing with measurements and mineral residue	The arrangement should match the Six-Key Sigil exactly, though this may not be stated in the caption.
35	Orin Flint's Depth Log	Mine ledger recording unexplained ticking, temperature changes, and moving echoes	Entries become increasingly uneasy before excavation is halted.
36	Fragment Recovered from Behind the Wall	Small piece of black-and-brass material with a living vein of light	The material reacts faintly when placed near Amelia's gauntlet.

VIII. “The Girl in the Reflection”

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
37	Reflection Canal Photographic Plate	Early long-exposure photograph showing Amelia beside an older reflected figure	In the physical scene Amelia stands alone; the second figure exists only in the water.

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
38	The Lady's Silver-White Gauntlet Study	Sketch reconstructed from Amelia's memory	Similar to Amelia's arm but more advanced, elegant, and nearly seamless.
39	The Sixth Door Warning	Amelia's handwritten recollection layered over rippled photographic evidence	Preserves the line: DO NOT LET HIM OPEN THE SIXTH DOOR. The identity of "him" remains unknown.
40	Canal Reflection Star Chart	Astronomical comparison between the stars reflected in the water and the real sky	The reflected constellation matches the impossible sky seen in the Grand Atrium.

IX. "The Door That Remembered Amelia"

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
41	The Sealed Atrium Door	Architectural photograph surrounded by close-up tracings of its engravings	The door appears blank until Amelia approaches, when the Living Key Emblem becomes visible.
42	The Bearer Inscription	Brass rubbing and partial Academy translation	Introduces Amelia's ancient title: Bearer of the Living Key. Leave part of the translation deliberately incomplete.
43	Prototype II and Amelia's Gauntlet Comparison	Academy comparison plate prepared in secret by Doctor Elara Quill	Shows that they share the same underlying geometry but were made using different materials and methods.
44	The First Mechanist Handwriting Comparison	Three documents placed side by side: ancient inscription, Amelia's gauntlet interior, and a recent pneumatic message	Confirms that the same hand—or machine—produced all three.

X. "The Living Key"

These should be among the most visually impressive artifacts in the first volume.

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
45	The Heart Engine Distribution Diagram	Monumental engineering lithograph with Golden Veins extending beneath the city	The public diagram shows an energy system. Hidden annotations suggest the flow may actually run toward the Engine.
46	Pulse Chamber Pressure Record	Long mechanical chart showing the Engine's rhythm changing when Amelia approaches	The pulse increasingly resembles a heartbeat rather than a turbine cycle.
47	The First Open Lock	Dark excavation photograph or charcoal reconstruction of one enormous lock opening beneath Aetherhaven	Ideal final artifact image for Volume One. It answers one question while opening the next volume's mystery.

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
48	The Living Key Prophecy Fragment	Torn illuminated manuscript with burned edges and missing lines	Avoid a complete prophecy. Preserve only fragments such as “when the little key awakens” and “the city shall remember.”

XI. Organizations and Secret Societies

These can appear gradually as seals, graffiti, documents, and recovered objects rather than as a single encyclopedia spread.

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
49	The Order of the Closed Eye Seal	Black wax impression over a partially redacted Council file	A closed mechanical eye with a tiny keyhole at its center.
50	The Ninth Guild Brand	Soot-black maker’s mark found on an illegal machine from the Cauldron	The numeral nine should be formed from a broken gear and curling pipe.
51	The Obsidian Covenant Insignia	Polished black metal badge that reflects no clear face	Formal, severe, and older than the city’s current government.
52	The Quiet Choir Vibration Transcript	Mechanical recording strip with decoded wave patterns	The translated phrase reads: THE LITTLE KEY HAS AWAKENED.
53	Custodians of the Six Keys Fragmentary Crest	Six broken seal fragments reconstructed on an archivist’s table	Reveals that the organization fractured into multiple factions.
54	The Unwound Broadside	Printed protest notice, handwritten edits, and an extremist symbol added later	Separates the peaceful reform movement from its more dangerous offshoot.
55	Brass Watch Restricted Incident File	Official report with photographs, witness notes, and heavy redactions	Could concern Inspector Thorne’s nonexistent expedition into the Shrouded Vaults.
56	High Council Thirteenth Seat Record	Formal seating chart showing twelve named officials and one sealed position	The thirteenth position is reserved for the First Mechanist.

XII. Background Lore and Transitional Artifacts

These enrich the city between major stories.

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
57	Aetherhaven Pneumatic Message Capsule	Object study with a fresh message signed by the First Mechanist	Makes the city’s communication infrastructure part of the mystery.
58	The Last Lantern Promise Ledger	Shop ledger containing promises instead of prices	Several promises have been fulfilled decades before they were written.
59	Theatre of Impossible Things Playbill	Elaborate printed program depicting a scene that later occurs	Introduces Madame Celestine Mirrow and the theatre’s predictive performances.

No.	Artifact image	Form	Canonical purpose
60	Lamplighter's Blue Flame Photograph	Night photograph of the memorial lamp that recently changed color	A quieter mystery suitable for an interlude or future standalone story.
61	Aerial Mariners' Forbidden Star Chart	Navigation chart with one star crossed out in every known hand	References the Shattered Lands without leaving Aetherhaven.
62	Southern Docks Unclaimed Cargo Plate	Photograph of a sealed foreign crate with frost, vines, or unfamiliar mechanisms	Allows the outer world to enter the city through visitors and cargo.
63	Old City Street Sign Palimpsest	Layered rubbings showing several older street names beneath the current one	Suggests that Aetherhaven's streets remember previous versions of the city.
64	Null Zone Instrument Test	Array of stopped clocks, failed compasses, and one active gauntlet reading	Visually establishes that Amelia's arm becomes stronger where every other machine fails.

Recommended First Generation Batch

The strongest opening set would be these twelve plates:

1. The Hawthorne Explorer's Crest - **Done**
2. The Six-Key Sigil - **Done**
3. The First Mechanist's Mark - **Done**
4. The Aether Gauntlet Exterior Study - **Done**
5. Prototype II Cabinet Photograph - **Done**
6. The Dream Blossom Botanical Plate - **Done**
7. The Changing Paths of the Gardens - **Done**
8. Tamsin Pike's Brass Key - **Done**
9. The Passenger's Future-Dated Ticket - **Done**
10. Gearbreaker Excavation Photograph
11. Reflection Canal Photographic Plate
12. The Heart Engine Distribution Diagram

Together, those establish the **family, central mystery, mechanical arm, Gardens, first major adventures, and hidden structure of Aetherhaven** without revealing too much too early.